

“Plausibly Deniable”

By Ryan Charles Lingo

Author's Note

This book is dedicated to Kyle, my friends, and my family.

To the friends who stayed, you know who you are. You were there during the worst of it and you made me feel heard when hearing me was not easy. That is not a small thing and I have not forgotten it.

To Kyle, you are a scientist and a rational one. You never reached for the easy explanation. You heard everything and you stayed. You made me feel heard without question, without hesitation. You were my anchor through all of it. You and my family are the reason I came home.

To my family, I love you. What you went through during that period was not okay, and I want you to know I have never forgotten that. You were asked to make sense of something that was designed not to make sense. You did the best you could with what you were given.

What you were given was not the truth.

The truth is in these pages. I hope you find it there.

To my nieces and nephews, you are why I wrote this. Every page of it.

To everyone who reads this — I want to say something before you turn the page.

There is a version of every story like this one that is easier to hold than the truth. It arrives quickly, it feels familiar, and it has the particular comfort of making the world make sense in a way that doesn't require you to change anything about how you understand it. It is the explanation that asks nothing of you.

I am asking you to resist it.

Not because the truth in these pages is comfortable. It isn't. Not because what happened to me is easy to accept. It isn't that either. I am asking you to resist the easy explanation because discomfort is not evidence of error. A story that makes you uneasy is not, by virtue of that unease, a story that isn't true. The people who designed what was done to me understood this. They built operations that depend on it. The architecture of plausibly deniable direction only works if the people around the target do exactly what they are designed to do, which is to look at each piece in isolation and conclude that nothing unusual has happened.

The documents in this book are real. The dates are real. The names are real. The contradiction at the center of this account — an eleven-message Air Force email chain on one side, a Pentagon official's denial to a United States Senator on the other — is not a matter of interpretation. It is a matter of record.

Read it carefully. Sit with what it adds up to. And when the easy explanation arrives, as it will, ask yourself who benefits from it being the one you choose.

Foreword

I want to tell you what this book is not.

It is not a conspiracy theory. It is not the account of someone who lost their grip on reality and is looking for an explanation. It is not speculation, inference, or the kind of story that depends on you trusting the narrator's interpretation of events.

It is a documented record. The documents exist. The dates exist. The names exist. The complaints were filed, the faxes were confirmed, the congressional letters were sent, the declinations were signed and returned. These are not claims I am asking you to take on faith. They are facts with paper trails, and where paper trails exist, I kept them.

What this book asks of you is not belief. It asks attention. Read what happened in the order that it happened. Read the names of the people involved and the titles they held and the dates on which they acted or failed to act. Read the list of every federal agency, every congressional office, every whistleblower attorney, and every newsroom I contacted between 2023 and 2026 in an attempt to find someone willing to look at what had been done to me and say: this matters.

Notice what the list adds up to.

I want to say something about the phrase *plausibly deniable*, because it is the title of this book, and because understanding what it means is understanding everything that follows.

It is not a metaphor I invented. It is a term of art, intelligence tradecraft, the specific architecture of operations designed so that each individual element can be explained away while the aggregate cannot. The mechanism depends on this: that reasonable people, presented with any single piece of the picture, will reach for the most ordinary explanation available. And reasonable people almost always do.

Documents disclosed by NSA contractor Edward Snowden revealed that British and American intelligence agencies developed explicit programs for discrediting, disrupting, and psychologically destabilizing targets through digital means. The techniques were named, documented, and trained. They were not theoretical.

Most people have seen this without knowing what to call it.

Think about the employee who raises an uncomfortable concern at work. Files a complaint, pushes back on something they shouldn't have, becomes inconvenient to the wrong person. They can't be fired for it. That would be retaliation, and retaliation leaves a paper trail, and a paper trail is liability. So something quieter happens instead. They

start getting left off meeting invites. Their projects migrate to someone else without explanation. A performance review surfaces concerns that were never raised in three years of positive feedback. Their access gets quietly downgraded. Their emails stop getting responses.

Every single one of those things has an explanation. A scheduling oversight. A reorganization. Honest feedback. A system update. Normal process.

And if that employee walks into HR and says they're being pushed out, HR looks at each piece individually, because that is how institutions are designed to look at things, and sees nothing actionable. A missed meeting invite is not evidence of anything. Neither is a reassigned project. Neither is a performance note. The system is not built to see the pattern. It is built to evaluate the pieces. And the pieces, by design, are clean.

That gap, between what the targeted person knows and what anyone with authority will acknowledge, is where plausibly deniable operations live. The goal was never to be invisible. The goal was to be unprovable.

Now imagine that same architecture, deployed not by a middle manager trying to protect his budget, but by people with security clearances, federal resources, and access to your devices. People trained in exactly this. People for whom deniability is not an afterthought. It is the first thing they build.

That is what this book is about.

This is a story that runs through the Federal Aviation Administration, a major defense contractor, and the Office of the Director of National Intelligence, the apex of the entire United States intelligence community, sitting above the CIA, the NSA, and fourteen other federal agencies. It involves a SECRET-level security clearance, a UAP research prototype that reached the highest levels of the national security apparatus, and a campaign of retaliation so carefully constructed that every federal agency, every congressional office, every whistleblower attorney, and every newsroom I contacted over three years found a reason to look away.

They had good reasons. The reasons were built in.

The design is the evidence. The deniability is the tell.

A note on how to read this book.

Read it in order. That is not a preference. It is a requirement for understanding what happened. The chapters are arranged chronologically because the sequence is the argument. Who I was before any of this happened matters, because it establishes what was taken. What I built matters, because it establishes why. What occurred on March

2nd, 2023 matters, because it establishes the mechanism. What came after matters, because it establishes the institutional response to that mechanism, which is to say, the absence of one.

Each chapter adds a layer. Each layer changes what the previous one means. If you skip ahead, you will find individual facts. If you read in sequence, you will find a pattern. The pattern is what this book is about.

The chapters do not editorialize. I have worked to let the facts carry the weight, and to resist the temptation to tell you what to think about them. You will draw your own conclusions. What I ask is that you draw them after reading everything, not before.

A note on names: everyone named in this book is named because the record requires it. I have not changed names to protect anyone who made decisions that harmed me and then ensured there was no paper trail connecting them to those decisions. The paper trail exists anyway. I kept it.

A note on what I'm asking: read carefully, hold the dates in your mind as you go, and notice what accumulates.

That's all. Just notice.

Ryan Charles Lingo, M.A. April 2026

Table of Contents

Author's Note	1
Foreword.....	3
Chapter 1: The Offer	7
Chapter 2: What I Saw.....	15
Chapter 3: The Second Project.....	20
Chapter 4: Inside	24
Chapter 5: The Noise	31
Chapter 6: The External Fight.....	37
Chapter 7: Benson and Bartlett.....	46
Chapter 8: The Cost	53
Epilogue: Still Fighting.....	60
About the Author	65

Chapter 1: The Offer

I poured the pills down the drain at around midnight.

The prescription was for a muscle relaxer, one I had canceled the day before. I hadn't ordered a refill. I hadn't asked for one. It had appeared anyway, and I had picked it up earlier that day without fully processing what that meant. By midnight I had processed it.

I stood at the sink for a moment after. The bottle was empty. I set it down.

Earlier that night, content had appeared in my feed suggesting I end my life. I won't describe it in detail. You'll understand why I don't need to. What I'll tell you is that by the time I poured those pills out, I understood the sequence: the content, the prescription, the timing. Each element alone was nothing. A social media algorithm. A pharmacy error. Together they were a sentence, and I had read it.

I was wearing a heart monitor. My watch had been flagging irregular readings for weeks, long enough that a doctor had fitted me with one. I reached up and pulled it off. I'm not entirely sure why. It felt like the right thing to do in that moment. I was done being read.

I didn't go to bed. I lay down on my bed instead, still dressed, staring at the ceiling in a state I can only describe as disbelief — not panic, not grief, just the flat, cold recognition that I had read the situation correctly and there was nothing I could do about it.

And then the lights went out.

Not a flicker. Not a surge. They went out the way lights go out when someone is making a point. I lay there in the complete dark and understood, with a clarity I cannot fully explain and do not expect you to simply accept, that I was being told to sleep.

I didn't sleep.

Four days later, on Monday March 6th, 2023, I picked up a spiral notebook and wrote down everything I could remember. My handwriting got tighter as I went, like I was trying to compress everything into a space small enough to hide. I wrote it all down the night before they took me. Before someone made me lose it. Four pages.

I started with Thursday. March 2nd. The day it happened.

Alarm at 5:10am. Drove to Dunkin' Donuts and 7-Eleven. Nicorette gum, medium coffee, half-decaf, half-regular. Coffee muffin. I wrote these things down because I needed the reader, whoever that might be, to understand that this was a normal morning. That I was a normal person. That I had no reason to expect what was coming.

By 7:30 I was at my desk.

The first thing I did that morning was move my Unidentified Aerial Phenomena (UAP) visualization script into a new GitHub account. GitHub is a cloud-based platform used to store and version-control code. The repository was named glass-violin. This wasn't my idea. The direction came the same way the rest of that day's instructions would come — through implication, through prompts, through the kind of operational guidance that leaves no fingerprints. I understood what was being asked. I did it.

The work I had spent months building — a prototype developed in response to statistically significant increases in UAP reports to the Air Traffic Control System Command Center (ATSCC), the tool that had earned an accepted abstract at the national ESRI conference — was now sitting in an account called glass-violin, separated from my name, waiting.

By 10:00am an ad appeared on my government laptop: a Microsoft Surface 9 tablet.

A few minutes later my personal phone buzzed. A text from CVS. A prescription was ready for pickup. It was the muscle relaxer I had canceled the day before. I hadn't ordered a refill. I hadn't asked for one. I picked it up on the way back from an errand. I didn't think about it too hard. That is the honest answer. I would think about it later. I would think about it very hard.

Two instructions through two devices before 10am. I noted it the way you note things when you don't yet have a word for what you're seeing.

By noon I was in an internal business development meeting.

David Williams was a senior Leidos leader who ran the monthly meetings for the National Airspace System Integration Support Contract (NISC). He was high enough that he met with all NISC employees regularly, and that seniority meant he sat at the top of the chain that governed my day-to-day work. He was calm, measured, the kind of person who made competence look effortless. I trusted him completely.

I would later come to understand, in the way you understand things only after they've happened to you, that he was very good at being trusted. His LinkedIn profile now lists his title at Leidos as Risk and Opportunity Lead. He received that promotion after everything I'm about to describe.

Make of that what you will.

There is a technique used in clandestine operations called plausibly deniable direction. It is not improvised. It is trained. The operator never issues a direct command — no written order, no explicit instruction, nothing that could be quoted back or traced. Instead, they guide through implication: a word choice here, a statement of fact there,

the deliberate narration of an example that functions as a template. The recipient understands. The record shows nothing.

David Williams was good at it. He was ex-Navy. That matters, because it explains the precision — this wasn't a contractor who had picked up a few tricks. This was someone trained in the methods. Someone who knew, from experience, exactly how much could be communicated without a single word of it being actionable.

I don't say that to diminish what was done to me. I say it because you need to understand that what happened in that meeting wasn't chaotic or clumsy. It was precise. He knew exactly what he was doing, and he did it well. A less skilled operator would have left seams. He didn't.

At some point during the meeting, documents appeared in my browser, delivered through Cisco. I was asked to confirm, in writing, that I consented to removing all history of Ryan C. Lingo and ryan.c.lingo@leidos.com from the relevant systems. Williams was speaking — not to me about the documents, not directly. But as he spoke, I understood what was being communicated. I signed them.

And then the excitement drained. I sat there for a moment — I don't know how long — trying to process why this was being asked of me. Signing documents that removed all history of my own name from the systems I worked in every day. I didn't understand it. I followed the instruction because I had followed every other instruction that day, and because the system I was inside had never given me a reason not to. But something in me paused. I just couldn't find the answer to why.

Then, separately, Webex appeared on my Leidos MacBook. I hadn't downloaded it. It had been pushed to the machine remotely. The account needed to be set up. I paused. I didn't know what name to use — no one had told me, and I hadn't thought that far ahead. I sat there for a moment with the cursor in the name field, blank. Then my FAA Bing homepage expanded — a sports advertisement featuring Riley Gaines, a competitive swimmer and prominent public figure. Riley. Ryan. Close enough. She was someone people knew. So was I supposed to be.

There was a rush to it. I want to be honest about that. For a moment it felt like recognition — like someone had finally seen what I was capable of beyond the geospatial tools and the data pipelines. I had been handed something that felt like a mission. I felt chosen.

Then came the audio. Every volume setting — notifications, speaker output, microphone levels — had to be zeroed out. No sound in, no sound out. This wasn't vague tradecraft instinct. There was a specific reason, and it was a logical one: Riley Gaines would appear in future meetings. Meetings that might include people who knew my voice. If I spoke as Riley Gaines and a colleague happened to be near whatever device that account was

running on, they would hear Ryan Lingo's voice coming out of a stranger's profile. The cover would be blown. The silence wasn't about secrecy in the abstract. It was about a very concrete operational problem with a very concrete solution.

I tried. I couldn't find all the settings. I closed the panel and moved on.

The meeting concluded the way meetings do. A few closing words, and the call ended.

Then my phone rang. A New Hampshire number. A woman on the line, asking about the Microsoft Surface tablet, the same one advertised on my government laptop at 10:00 that morning. I told her I was a representative of Riley Gaines. I gave her an address where the new laptop could be sent.

My phone alerted. I don't remember now whether it was a notification banner, a sound, or just the screen lighting up. What I remember is that something made me look at it. I opened my Reminders app.

There were three entries. I hadn't written any of them.

The first said: *I am Riley Gaines.*

The second had a pin symbol next to it: *Leaving Ryan's Home.*

The third: *Messaging Eric Cady (FAA).*

I stared at them for a moment. This is the part that's hardest to explain to someone who hasn't experienced it — not the fear, not the anger, but the disorientation. You are being given instructions through a device you own, in an app you use, written in your own interface, and no one has said a single word to you directly. There is no briefing. There is no handler. There is no one you can turn to and ask what any of this means. There is just the screen, and three lines, and the understanding that you are expected to know what to do next.

I hadn't been trained for any of this. That's the part that still sits with me. They built the whole apparatus — the alias, the documents, the routing, the reminders — and then they handed it to someone with no preparation and expected it to work. Why wouldn't they have trained me? That question doesn't have a flattering answer for the people who designed this.

I tried to finish the audio settings on Webex. I couldn't get them to work. I gave up.

The shopping that followed was pre-sorted, calibrated to a new duty location. Riverside, California. I had applied for a cartographer position with U.S. Customs and Border Protection (CBP) there in February — the USAJOBS posting had been selected earlier in the week. The ads knew this. Items appeared in sequence, organized the way you'd organize a relocation: clothing, equipment, a place to live. At some point a realtor

appeared. Someone to help me find a place in Riverside. I don't remember if it was an ad or a link. I remember that it was there.

From the outside, nothing had happened. From the inside, I had just created a false identity on a work-issued device, signed documents erasing my own name, and answered a phone call as someone else — all under remote observation, using a communication method specifically designed to ensure that no one — not a court, not an investigator, not an Office of Inspector General (OIG) — could point to a single sentence David Williams had said and call it an order.

He was that good.

Then came the bank.

The directions came through an internal Leidos mapping application, not consumer Google Maps. Operational detail embedded directly into the route. Green Line to Chinatown. Chinatown to Farragut Square. Walk three blocks to United Bank.

At some point I was running late. The application told me to wait. I waited at the second-to-last stop on the line. While I sat there, an ad opened automatically on my phone: a loan application through the Department of Commerce Federal Credit Union (DOCFCU), for \$10,000. I noted it. I kept waiting.

When I arrived I wasn't sure who I was supposed to be. Ryan Lingo or Riley Gaines. I was alone. There was one woman working. I was nervous in a specific way — not the adrenaline of earlier, nothing like that. This was the fear of being seen through. Of saying the wrong word, making the wrong move, giving her a reason to look at me twice. I handed over my license. My real name. Ryan Lingo. Not Riley Gaines. I wasn't sure in that moment which one I was supposed to be, and that uncertainty sat in my chest the whole time I stood at that counter. She handed me the document to open a new account. I took it. I didn't say anything I shouldn't have. I walked out.

I took the metro home.

I wrote all of this down on March 6th because I was trying to hold onto it. The next morning, I was hospitalized. I was in and out of facilities for five weeks. While I was there, Leidos contacted my mother and directed her to ship my Leidos-issued laptop back to the company. The laptop contained my UAP research, the alias account, the code repository — everything. I was in no position to stop it. The official language across all of it was psychiatric. I'd describe it differently — as what happens when a person's entire reality is systematically undermined, the evidence is removed while they cannot act, and no one believes them.

But this story doesn't start on March 2nd, 2023. It starts earlier, with a job offer, a security clearance, and a genuine belief that the work I was doing mattered.

I am a geographer. That's not a dramatic thing to say, but it's the foundation of everything that follows. I see the world spatially — in patterns, in data, in the relationship between where things are and what they mean. I have a Master's degree. I know how to build systems that visualize information in three dimensions. I know how to look at a dataset and find the thing that doesn't belong.

I was twenty-nine years old and living alone in the Navy Yard neighborhood of Washington, D.C., twenty minutes from the White House, in an apartment I'd chosen specifically because of where it put me in relation to everything I was working toward. I was single. I had no one waiting up for me. What I had was proximity to the work, and that felt like enough.

Geography had found me through a specific pull toward remote sensing and satellite imagery — the idea that you could sit in a room and read the surface of the Earth, that patterns invisible from the ground became obvious from altitude. I wanted to do research. I wanted to contribute something lasting to the field. I had a quiet certainty, the kind you don't say out loud, that I was built for something significant. I didn't know yet what form that would take.

I still believe I was right about that. I just couldn't have predicted the shape of it.

Before Leidos I had been a federal employee — a Geographer for the United States Census Bureau, based in Washington. I was not new to this world. I had already been inside it.

That skill is what got me the job at Leidos.

The offer came through an unusual channel. My ex-partner was a contractor at FBI headquarters in Washington, working for Deloitte on a federal contract. He asked around, put my name and background in front of the right people, and I was told to apply. That's how it works in this world. Credentials matter, but so does who knows you exist. And in a city built on contracts layered beneath contracts, the people who know you exist are often contractors too.

The financial step up from my previous federal position was significant. But money wasn't what made me say yes. The mission was. The idea that my work would contribute to the security of the national airspace — that the tools I built would be used by people making real decisions about what was happening in the sky — that's what I wanted. I wasn't taking a contractor job. I was joining something.

Leidos is one of the largest defense contractors in the United States. Billions in government contracts. Thousands of employees embedded across federal agencies — the

FAA, the Department of Defense, the intelligence community. When you work for Leidos, you don't always know exactly who you're working for. The contracts layer on top of each other. The clearances determine what you're allowed to know. You learn to operate inside the boundaries of what you've been told, and you trust that the people above you are operating in good faith.

I trusted that.

My assignment was with the Federal Aviation Administration, within the Operations Security Strategic Initiatives Team — AJR-223, Automation Support. My role wasn't simply to write code and move on. I was brought in as a subject matter expert (SME) on internal geography applications — the person the team came to when they needed to understand how spatial data worked, how it should be structured, what it could and couldn't tell you. That distinction matters. An SME isn't just executing someone else's vision. You're shaping how the organization understands its own information.

I worked across multiple projects. I built and maintained geospatial tools. I translated complex spatial datasets into something operationally useful for people who didn't think in coordinates and projections. My supervisor, Matthew Thompson, was supportive. My colleagues were competent. The mission felt real: keeping the national airspace safe, building tools that helped people understand what was happening in the sky.

I was good at it. That's not arrogance. It's relevant. Because one of the things you need to understand about what happened next is that I wasn't a peripheral figure. I wasn't someone who stumbled onto something by accident. I was embedded, trusted, and doing work that people relied on.

What I didn't fully appreciate at the time was where the FAA sat in the broader national security architecture. The FAA isn't just a civilian agency managing flight paths. Its airspace data - what's moving, where, at what altitude, with what transponder signature - is shared with and monitored by defense and intelligence entities whose names don't appear on the agency's public website. The security operations team I worked within existed precisely at that intersection. I was a geographer who had been placed, whether I fully understood it or not, at a point where civilian aviation infrastructure met the intelligence community.

I signed my SF-312 — the Classified Information Nondisclosure Agreement, prescribed by the Office of the Director of National Intelligence — on April 26, 2022. I initialed eight provisions. I understood what I was agreeing to.

What I didn't know then was that my work was also being shared with ODNI directly. That behind the FAA contract, there were other eyes on what I was building. I wouldn't learn that until much later — until I was trying to explain to a congressional staffer why a Geographic Information Systems (GIS) developer from Pennsylvania had ended up at

the center of something that reached into the highest levels of the national security apparatus.

But in the spring of 2022, I was just glad to have the job.

I had a government laptop. A security badge. A challenge coin that Eric Cady, a specialist in FAA Special Operations, handed me personally at the ESRI User Conference that July. The FAA seal on one side, *System Operations Security – Special Operations* on the back. I kept it. It felt like proof of something. Proof that I had earned my place inside the machine.

I believed in the machine.

That belief is important to understand, because everything that comes after — every complaint filed, every door closed, every night I spent wondering if I was losing my mind — has to be measured against how completely I trusted the system before it turned on me.

I wasn't a dissident. I wasn't looking for a fight. I was a geographer, trying to do good work. In January 2023, six weeks before March 2nd, I submitted a Schedule A letter to the FAA People with Disabilities Program — a federal hiring pathway for persons with neurodevelopmental disabilities. I submitted a similar application to the United States Space Force. I was trying to move from contractor to federal employee through every legitimate pathway available to me. I was not someone on the margins of the federal workforce. I was someone trying to move deeper into it.

And then, in the summer of 2022, I noticed something in the data.

Chapter 2: What I Saw

The tool didn't exist until I made it exist.

That's the thing people don't fully understand about this kind of work. There was no template, no existing system I was adapting or improving. I was writing Python scripts from scratch, in my apartment in Navy Yard, building something that had no predecessor in this specific application. This was before the current wave of AI tools made that kind of development accessible to anyone with a browser and a prompt. It was just me, the language, and a problem that wouldn't leave me alone.

The reports came in through two channels. The first was Skywatch — an internal FAA application I had access to as part of my role. UAP reports filed by pilots and aircraft operators were stored there alongside other sensitive airspace data. The same system housed information regarding President of the United States (POTUS) and Vice President of the United States (VPOTUS) movements — I did not have access to that data, but its presence in the same system speaks to the sensitivity and scope of what Skywatch was. I could filter them by different criteria. Not because anyone told me to. Because the data was there and I was curious and that is what you do when you are a geographer with access to a system that tracks everything moving through national airspace. The second channel was senior leadership, funneling selected reports down through the Air Traffic Control System Command Center — the ATSCC, the national nerve center where every aircraft in U.S. airspace is tracked in real time. Other analysts were already dashboarding them, and what the dashboards were showing was hard to ignore: UAP reports were increasing at a statistically significant rate. That finding didn't come from me. It came from the institutional apparatus doing what it was built to do — measuring, tracking, flagging. The numbers said something was happening.

My job was to ask what.

The reports that made their way to me came through Matthew Thompson. Aircraft operators, pilots and crew who had seen something they couldn't explain and filed accordingly. By the time they reached me they had already passed through institutional hands. Leadership had looked at them and decided they were worth examining. That pre-selection mattered. These weren't fringe reports scraped from the internet. These were documented encounters that the FAA had determined deserved a closer look.

John Evans was an FAA employee I worked closely with during this period — one of the few people I could show the work to in real time, the only person who saw my excitement as it was happening rather than after the fact. That matters in this kind of work. When you're building something alone, in an apartment, over months, you need at least one person who can look at the screen and understand what they're seeing. John was that person. He was sharp — genuinely technical, the kind of person who could

engage with the architecture of what I was building rather than just the surface of it. At one point there was a specific method in Skyfield — an open-source Python library for tracking objects in space — that we worked through together, a detail in the implementation that mattered for the geometry to be right. He understood it. That kind of collaboration, small as it was, meant something.

What we were building, eventually, was this: a three dimensional render of the airspace. You could input an aircraft's callsign and altitude — a real flight, a real moment — and the tool would place it in space. Then it would map the orbital paths of satellites against that position. Starlink satellites specifically — a commercial constellation of low-Earth orbit satellites launched by SpaceX — the ones whose geometry, at the right sun angle, would produce exactly the kind of anomalous brightness a pilot might report as something unknown.

You could draw a line. Aircraft to satellite. And either the geometry worked — the sun was right, the angle was right, the orbit intersected — or it didn't.

Months of scripting for that. Months of iteration, of running the code and finding what was wrong with it, of slowly building something precise enough to be trusted. At some point Leidos noticed. A short internal broadcast feature landed in my email, a quiet institutional acknowledgment that what I was building was worth knowing about. I bookmarked it. I didn't think too hard about what it meant at the time.

I worked at my standing desk. The apartment was quiet. I had the data and I had the problem and I had time, and I put all three together the way you do when you believe the work is worth doing.

I believed the work was worth doing.

I couldn't stop thinking about it.

That's the honest description of where I was during that period — not stuck, not frustrated, but absorbed in the way you get absorbed when you're building something that keeps revealing itself to you. The work followed me off the clock. Into evenings. Into weekends. I'd step away from the standing desk and the problem would come with me, turning over quietly in the background the way good problems do when you're close to something.

It was on a weekend that it arrived.

My grandmother had a saying she'd used her whole life. Red in the morning, sailors take warning. Red at night, sailors delight. It's an old piece of weather wisdom — the color of the sky at different times of day telling you something about what light is doing, where it's coming from, what it means. She hadn't said it to me recently. She couldn't. She had passed away that summer, while I was deep in this work. But her voice showed up

anyway, the way the voices of people we've lost sometimes do — not as memory exactly, but as presence. As something useful arriving from somewhere you didn't expect.

I needed to add sunlight to the orbital paths.

That was what the saying unlocked. The satellite geometry alone wasn't enough. A Starlink satellite passing overhead meant nothing without knowing whether the sun was at the right angle to illuminate it — to turn it from an invisible object in the sky into something bright and anomalous and worth reporting. The light was the variable I hadn't fully accounted for. And once I accounted for it, the tool worked the way I had always believed it could.

Most of the reports resolved. Starlink satellites, sunlit at the right moment, visible from the right altitude and position. Pilots and operators seeing something real — just not something unknown. The tool visualized the orbit segments individually — short discrete lines, each one representing just a few seconds of movement in time, rendered in three dimensional space above the aircraft position. Imagine standing beneath the open sky and seeing those brief segments suspended overhead, each one a snapshot of something moving fast. The geometry explained it. You could see the line between the aircraft and the orbit segment, the sun angle, the moment of intersection. You could see exactly what they had seen and why they had seen it.

My grandmother had spent her whole life reading the sky. She just didn't know she'd one day help someone build a tool that did the same thing.

I wished I could have told her.

On November 1st, 2022, we submitted the abstract.

The full title was “Comparing Reports of Unidentified Aerial Phenomena to Starlink Satellite Orbits.” Abstract #1240. Submitted to the 2023 ESRI User Conference, the largest GIS conference in the world, held every year in San Diego. Twenty thousand attendees. The most significant platform in the field.

The names on it were Matthew Thompson, John Evans, and mine. That was Thompson's call. The federal employees had their names on it, and I was the contractor who had built the thing. I didn't argue with the order. I understood how it worked. What mattered was that the work was going out into the world under my name, attached to something real, something that could be evaluated and tested and built upon.

I was beyond excited. This was going to be the biggest moment of my career. The conference was scheduled for July 10th through the 14th in San Diego. I knew there would be preparation: slides, a presentation, the kind of public-facing work that's different from building something alone at a standing desk. I was anxious about that

part. But underneath the anxiety was something I hadn't felt in a long time: the certainty that I had done something worth showing.

The tool existed. The work was documented. My name was on it.

A few weeks later, someone forwarded me an email. My screenshots had reached ODNI.

Not every report pointed to a satellite.

That's the part that requires care to describe accurately, because it's easy to overstate and easy to understate, and both would be dishonest. The tool worked on all of them. That's the first thing to understand. It wasn't that the visualization broke down or the methodology failed. It was that when you drew the line — aircraft to orbit segment, sun angle, geometry — sometimes nothing was there. No Starlink constellation at the right position. No sunlit object that could account for what had been reported.

The tool was precise enough to rule satellites out. That's what it was built to do, not just confirm explanations but test them. And some reports didn't confirm.

We weren't the only ones running reports through the tool. I remember at least one other person working through a few themselves — testing the visualization against different sightings, getting familiar with what it could show. When a report came back without a satellite explanation, the response wasn't alarm. It wasn't excitement. It was closer to what any careful researcher feels at the edge of their methodology — a kind of professional acknowledgment that the data had taken us as far as it could.

I remember thinking: there's probably an explanation. We just don't have it yet. That's not a dramatic conclusion. It's an honest one. The absence of a satellite explanation didn't mean the absence of any explanation — it meant we had eliminated one category and whatever remained was outside the scope of what I had built.

We moved on. The work continued. Nobody stopped. Nobody panicked. We noted what the tool had found and what it hadn't, and we kept going.

That's what rigor looks like from the inside. It doesn't feel like revelation. It feels like work.

The tool had one more capability worth describing.

Built into the visualization was a line of sight function — not something I had added as an afterthought, but a deliberate analytical feature. A user could draw their own line. Aircraft to orbit segment. You could take a specific report, place the aircraft in three dimensional space at its logged altitude and callsign, and then manually trace the geometry yourself — pulling a line from the cockpit position out toward the orbit segments suspended above it, testing whether the angle worked, whether the light

worked, whether what the pilot had seen could be accounted for by what was moving overhead.

It was designed to give the analyst agency. Not just to run reports through an automated filter but to interrogate individual cases by hand, to bring human judgment into contact with the data at the level of a single sighting. You could see what the pilot would have seen. You could test it yourself.

I had sent screenshots of the visualization to people within the FAA. That was normal. The work was being shared, discussed, passed around in the way that work gets passed around when people find it useful. I didn't think too hard about where the screenshots were going. I was focused on the tool.

A few weeks before March 2nd, Gary Miller, Director of Air Traffic Organization (ATO) Security, AJR2, made me aware that my screenshots had reached ODNI. The Office of the Director of National Intelligence is not a place that receives routine contractor work. It sits above the CIA, the NSA, the DIA, and fourteen other federal intelligence agencies - the apex of the entire apparatus. For a Python script built at a standing desk in a Navy Yard apartment to land there meant someone, somewhere above my clearance level, had decided it was worth passing up.

I don't know who sent them. I don't know what was said about them. What I know is that the email made its way to me, and I saw his name on it.

I went back to my standing desk after that. The apartment was quiet. The tool was running. Outside, the city moved the way it always did, oblivious, unhurried, unconcerned with what was happening in a Navy Yard apartment twenty minutes from the White House.

Two weeks later they made me transfer the code.

Chapter 3: The Second Project

I wanted the extra work.

That's the honest place to start, not with what happened, but with where I was when I walked into it. The UAP visualization was going well. My abstract was submitted. I had something to show. And when the opportunity came to take on another project under the NISC contract, I said yes without hesitation. I wanted to prove I could carry more than one thing at a time. That I was the kind of person worth investing in.

It was Jim Estes who asked me. Jim managed the task order and was the person I reported to day to day, affable, sharp in his own way, the kind of colleague who made work feel collegial. He framed it casually, the way you frame something when the answer is already assumed. David Williams needed someone for a financial dashboarding project. Was I interested? I was. I didn't know then that Jim asking instead of David telling was itself a structure. That the distance between the request and the person who wanted it filled was deliberate.

The Leidos office was on Virginia Avenue in Washington, D.C., their Capitol Hill office. The conference room had large windows. I remember that specifically: the light coming in, the kind of room that feels important before anything important has happened in it.

The day before my onboarding I was in that building for something else. Four FAA senior leaders walked past me and into that room. I watched them go. I didn't think about it too hard. The next day I would be sitting where they had sat, and I didn't know that yet.

I met David Williams in person for the first time.

He was tall. The meeting was short. He laid out the project the way you lay out something that doesn't require much explaining: four financial dashboards, employee data, here's what we need. The kind of task description that's over before you've finished writing it down. I nodded. I was ready to work. If the project felt thin in that room I told myself that was fine. Thin projects had a way of expanding once you got into them.

What I didn't know then — what I wouldn't understand until much later — was that the dashboarding project wasn't the project. It was the reason I was there. The cover for why a GIS developer with a SECRET clearance and a UAP visualization tool needed a laptop and a reason to be working late.

I already had a government-issued laptop for my FAA work. The UAP visualization, the data pipelines, the ESRI abstract — all of it lived on that machine. This was different. This laptop came from Leidos. Standard issue, supposedly. Except when I opened it in a dim room on Virginia Avenue — the lights low in a way that felt deliberate, different

from the bright open spaces I associated with normal Leidos environments — it hadn't been cleared. The previous user's data was still on it. YouTube videos. Browser history. Someone else's digital life sitting on a machine that had been handed to me as though it were clean. I noted it. It felt sketchy in a way I couldn't fully articulate — not alarm exactly, more like the low-grade unease of something that should have been routine not being routine. I called Leidos to have it wiped. Nobody treated this as unusual except me.

Leidos had provided a compromised machine to a contractor they were positioning for a covert operation. That was not a coincidence.

I came in more than once during that period. Getting the laptop sorted. Getting set up. New chargers. A YubiKey — a physical hardware security token used for two-factor authentication on sensitive systems. I noted that too, the way I had noted the uncleared laptop. Financial dashboards don't typically require that level of access infrastructure. I didn't say anything. I was new. I told myself there were things about government contracting I didn't fully understand yet.

Carey Seery was my security officer, the person assigned to manage my clearance. Her official title was Contract Support, Security Representative, Lead. Her job was to know things about the people she was responsible for. I understood that later. At the time she just seemed like someone who liked to talk.

We would sit together at the end of the day sometimes, the kind of loose, winding conversations that happen when the formal work is done and the office has gone quiet. She overshared the way some people do when they're comfortable — gossip, personal detail, the texture of her life outside the building. She told me about her home, contractors she was having trouble with, the ordinary frustrations of owning a place and managing the people you've hired to fix it.

More than once, across those months, she asked if I wanted to move in. She had space available. She brought it up the way you bring up something you've decided is a reasonable idea — not once as an offhand comment, but repeatedly, in different conversations, at different moments. I never understood why she kept pushing it. I never said yes. But every time she mentioned it something in me registered it as strange, the way you register things that don't have an obvious place yet.

She also told me about a former employee. More than once. He had gambled away everything he had. Then he died of an overdose. She never told me his name. She never explained why she kept telling me. I didn't ask. I filed it away with the home invitation, in the same unmarked folder.

Looking back, it felt like a warning. I still can't tell you exactly what she was warning me about. I don't know if she knew what was coming or whether she was simply a person

who had seen enough of this world to understand that some situations have predictable endings. What I know is that it never sat right with me. And I know that after everything happened — after March 2nd, after all of it — she never reached out.

The last email I received from her read:

Ryan, Good afternoon! I understand you resigned from the company. There are debriefing forms that are required to be completed that I have attached to this email. If you could please complete them and return them to me at your earliest convenience I can get them processed. Thank you and good luck in your future endeavors!

Debriefing forms. Future endeavors. That was the sum of it.

The two weeks between that first meeting and March 2nd are mostly gone now. Trauma does that — it doesn't erase evenly. It takes whole stretches and leaves you with fragments, impressions, the emotional residue of a period without the sequential memory to match.

I remember David Williams being kind to me during that period. That's the thing about what came later that's hardest to hold — how warm he was in the weeks before it. He asked about my motorized scooter. I had asked him where I could charge it. He didn't send me to facilities or tell me to submit a request. He walked me to a room himself and showed me where to plug it in. He told me about walking barefoot in the grass. Something about grounding, the body connecting to the earth. There was an Instagram trend around it at the time. He mentioned it the way people mention things they've adopted recently, with the slight self-consciousness of someone who has decided to believe in something new. He talked about his own struggles with weight, his work with a life coach. The kind of personal detail people share when they want you to feel like you know them. I listened. I asked questions. That's what I do with people. I try to hear them, understand who they are through what they choose to share. What David Williams chose to share, consistently, was warmth. It worked. I felt seen.

Underneath all of it things moved faster than they should have. There was an urgency I couldn't name at the time. A project that had barely been explained was already in motion. I told myself that was just how government contracting worked. Hurry up and wait, then suddenly hurry again.

I was wrong about what the hurry was for.

I didn't know yet that being seen and being watched are not the same thing.

I was happy to be there. I want to say that clearly because it matters for everything that follows. I wasn't suspicious. I wasn't looking for exits. I was a contractor who had built something real, whose abstract had been accepted at the largest GIS conference in the

world, who was now sitting in a dim room in a Capitol Hill office getting set up for a new project with senior people who knew his name.

I was exactly where I had worked to be.

I never built the dashboards.

I want to be clear about that because it matters. The project that brought me into David Williams' orbit, that put a Leidos laptop in my hands, that gave me a reason to be in that conference room — I never got to it. Within two weeks, before I had written a single line of code, March 2nd happened. The project existed long enough to position me. Then it had served its purpose.

The UAP visualization. The GitHub repository. The alias. That's what March 2nd looked like from the inside. And when I try to trace it back to where it started — not the day it broke open, but the day I walked into it — I keep coming back to that conference room. The large windows. The short meeting. David Williams telling me what the project was, casual and certain, the way someone describes something they already know the ending to.

On the morning of March 7th I texted Jim Estes.

I am resigning. Due to an ethics related issue. And unfortunately I do not want to speak with you at this time.

That was my documented statement, in writing, at the moment I still had enough clarity to make it. I knew what had happened. I knew what I was walking away from. I named it — an ethics issue — because that's what it was.

By the end of that day I was no longer in a position to act on my own resignation. My family, not understanding what I was resigning from or why, made sure I kept the job. They thought they were helping.

David Williams texted me on March 8th. He was still warm. Still there. By March 19th he had stopped responding entirely.

The operator had exited cleanly. The record showed nothing.

Chapter 4: Inside

The first thing I did when I got home was ask my parents to help me find a lawyer. I don't remember which one they found. What I remember is telling my mother repeatedly that day. I need a lawyer. Not because I didn't know what had happened. Because I did.

On March 5th, two days after I got home and two days before Brooke Glen, I sent a fax to the Department of Homeland Security (DHS) Office of Inspector General. I described what had happened. I signed my name to it. I filed a federal complaint because I knew exactly what had been done to me.

That document exists. It is dated March 5, 2023.

I was admitted to Brooke Glen Behavioral Health on March 7th, 2023. By that point the sequence of events since March 2nd had made that outcome feel inevitable to everyone around me.

The clothes were the first thing.

Everyone on the unit was wearing them — soft, drawstring-less, nothing with edges or weight or anything that could be repurposed. The architecture of the outfit said the same thing the building said, which was: *we know what people do when they're alone with certain objects, and we have thought about it more than you have*. I registered this the way I had been registering everything for weeks, which was to say immediately and without being able to do anything about it.

They all stopped and looked at me when I came in.

Not aggressively. Just the particular attention of a closed population when something new enters it. Sizing me up. Figuring out why I was there, what category I fit, whether I was someone to be cautious of or someone who could be absorbed into the unit's existing social order. I had the thought — and I knew even then how it would sound — *why is he here*. That was what I read in the looks. That was the question being turned back on me. I was the one who seemed like he didn't belong. I was the one whose outside was still showing.

The building was dilapidated. Small. Unclean in the way that buildings get when the people running them have stopped seeing the people inside them. The staff moved through the unit with the particular efficiency of people who had learned not to look too directly at what they were administering. You were processed. You were assigned. You were placed.

I was placed on a unit.

Two of the men there were military. I registered that the way you register certain things when your pattern recognition has been running hot for weeks. You notice. You file it. You don't say anything because there is no one to say it to.

One of them told me, within the first day, that he liked getting stabbed.

He said it the way you'd mention a preference for a particular kind of weather. Conversationally. Like he was offering something about himself so I'd know who I was dealing with. I nodded. I had nothing to offer in return that would have made sense in that context. *I think my employer used my psychiatric history to try to get me to overdose* is not a statement that plays well in a psychiatric facility. I had already learned that. I was in the facility because of what happened when people decided what my perceptions meant.

So I kept the logic to myself.

But the logic didn't stop running. It ran every night.

The medication was supposed to help me sleep. It didn't, or not enough, or not in any way that felt like actual rest. I would lie in the dark and the question would come back the same way it had been coming back since March 2nd. *Why did they have me pick up the medication the same day as the alias*. Not with a question mark — it had stopped being a question. It was a sequence. Prescription canceled. Prescription refilled without my request. Pickup same day as the alias account, the GitHub repository, the documents signed under direction. They knew my history. They had access. They knew what my past looked like and they built the day around it.

I couldn't say that out loud. I was already here.

We took breaks outside. That was the rhythm of the unit — structured time outdoors, back inside, structured time indoors, repeat. It gave the day a shape that didn't require you to think about what the day actually was.

We were outside on one of those breaks when it happened.

I don't remember exactly what we were doing. Probably nothing. Standing. The particular quality of time that exists in those places where there is nowhere to be and nothing to accomplish and the minutes pass the way minutes pass when you are waiting for something you cannot name.

We came back inside.

He was on the floor. The paramedics were already there or arrived very quickly — that part is compressed in the way emergency moments compress. What I remember clearly

is the stretcher. The body on it. The particular stillness of someone who has gone somewhere else and may not come back.

He had collected the pills. That was how it worked, apparently — you learned this, the way you learn the architecture of any place you're confined to. He had been collecting them and he had taken them all at once while we were outside. By the time we came back in the paramedics were working over him on the floor and then he was on the stretcher and then he was gone, transferred out to a hospital from the hospital, and the unit absorbed the absence the way units absorb things, which is to say not at all and completely simultaneously.

I stood there and understood something I could not say to anyone in that building.

That was supposed to be me.

Not him specifically — I didn't know him, not really. But the shape of it. The pills. The timing. The system that was supposed to be keeping you safe being the same system that handed you the means. I had poured my pills down the drain at midnight. I had read the sentence. And now I was watching the sentence play out on someone else's body and I was supposed to have no context for it.

I had context. I didn't sleep that night either.

They discharged me from Brooke Glen after seven days.

I had already started driving back to DC when I stopped.

Somewhere in Pennsylvania, maybe 45 minutes from home, close enough that turning around was still a real option. I pulled over and called my mother. I told her I couldn't go back.

She was trying. I believe that. The specifics of what she said are gone but the shape of it remains — she was offering home, the possibility that this was over, that the simple thing was the right thing. The sound of a person who loved me trying to find the version of this that made sense.

I looked at the navigation while she talked.

My Polestar had filled in a destination. I hadn't touched it. I hadn't entered anything. The screen showed Riverside, California — 2,700 miles, turn left, here is your route, here is where you are going next.

Riverside was where the CBP job was. The one I had applied for on February 23rd, one week before March 2nd. The announcement had closed on March 7th — the same day I was admitted to Brooke Glen.

I didn't tell my mother about the screen. There was no version of that sentence that helped anything. She was offering home and the car was offering Riverside and I was somewhere between the two of them, 45 minutes from a place I had grown up in, unable to go forward and not yet able to go back.

I went back.

During that period I called Leidos. More than once. I have a text from Zoey confirming she received one of my voicemails. I was not calling to ask for help. I was calling to put them on notice — that I intended to pursue arbitration, that I was not going to let this go quietly.

At some point during those communications she said it.

“We don't want things to get messy.”

I know what that meant. An institution that had just watched one of its contractors get hospitalized, lose his access and lose his evidence was telling him that pursuing accountability would be inconvenient for them. Dressed up as HR language. Delivered to a person who had just gotten out of a psychiatric facility.

The calls from that period are mostly gone. I got a new phone number afterward. The text from Zoey is what remains.

The following day the accident happened.

I will not put the details on this page. What I'll tell you is that by that point I had not slept properly in nearly two weeks — five days from March 2nd through admission, seven more days at Brooke Glen where the medication was supposed to help and didn't, not really, not in any way that felt like actual rest. They had taken me off the medications I knew and put me on ones I didn't. The ground under every thought had been shifting for two weeks straight. I was not the same person who had driven to Dunkin' Donuts on the morning of March 2nd and ordered a medium coffee, half-decaf, half-regular, and thought the day was going to be ordinary.

My family made the decision that followed. Under Pennsylvania law a family member can sign a document stating that you cannot make certain determinations for yourself and that keeping you safe requires removing your ability to choose. It means the next facility doesn't ask if you want to come in.

I didn't get to say no.

Horsham was cleaner than Brooke Glen. That's the most I'll say in its favor.

By the time I arrived I had been awake in any meaningful sense for close to two and a half weeks. The medications they gave me were heavy. Not restoring — just weighted. There is a difference between being sedated and being restored and I learned it there.

The question I had been running at Brooke Glen was gone by Horsham. Not answered. Gone. There was nothing left to run it on.

I met a woman who told me she worked for the federal government. She told me there were angels standing behind me. I did not tell her what I knew about the federal government. I did not tell her what had put me in that room.

I met a man who said he worked for the federal government and had seen real live aliens. He told me his family members were in the government and held high ranking positions. He told me he had a clearance. He wore something over his face and hair — covering himself, hiding his identity from whoever he believed was watching. He believed it completely.

I didn't talk to him much.

I want to be careful about why. It wasn't that I thought he was wrong about everything. It was that I had stopped. I had been mutilated and exhausted into silence by that point. I was not going to sit in a psychiatric facility and tell a man with his face covered that I understood something about what it meant to know a thing you couldn't prove to anyone's satisfaction. I was not going to give anyone in that building one more data point.

So I watched the ceiling instead.

I found out later that the social worker assigned to my case had a father who worked for the NSA. She didn't believe me either.

Outside, things were happening that I didn't know about yet.

My abstract had been accepted. ESRI had notified Matthew Thompson on March 15th — eight days after Brooke Glen, while I was still inside. Thompson forwarded it to Jim Estes and called it really cool work. A confirmation was sitting somewhere in an inbox, waiting for me to accept the presentation slot. July. Thousands of people. The work I had built alone in my apartment in Navy Yard.

I couldn't accept it. I didn't know it existed. My FAA account had been removed while I was incapacitated. My Leidos access was gone. There was no inbox I could reach, no

system I could log into, no way to respond to a confirmation that was sitting somewhere waiting for me. The window closed while I was in no position to open it.

That was not an accident. I was hospitalized on March 7th. The abstract was accepted on March 15th. The notification went to Matthew Thompson and Jim Estes — not to me. By the time I was out, the path to that stage had been closed from the other end.

In a different version of this story, I would have been on that stage in San Diego with my two colleagues, in front of thousands of people, showing work that had taken months to build and that no one had built before. That was the version I had been working toward.

The presentation slot expired. The work existed. They made sure I never got to show it.

Jim Estes emailed my personal Gmail. Asked how I was doing. Said he was proud of the UAP visualization work. Mentioned HR would need a doctor's note through Sedgwick, Leidos's third-party disability and leave management provider.

Proud of the work. Doctor's note through Sedgwick.

On March 29th, Sedgwick completed a Provider Statement. The form checked "delusional ideations evident: Yes." It noted paranoid delusions under reasoning and judgment.

The abstract was accepted on March 15th. I was delusional on March 29th. Both documents exist. Both were produced by people operating within the same institutional apparatus.

By that point I had not slept properly in close to three weeks. Five days from March 2nd through admission. Seven more days at Brooke Glen where the medication was supposed to help and didn't. Then the accident. Then the commitment. Then Horsham. Three weeks without real sleep, on medications I didn't know, after the most destabilizing sequence of events of my life.

Three weeks without sleep will affect any person's state of mind. That is not a diagnosis. That is biology.

Whatever state I was in when they evaluated me, the work existed before they got to me. The UAP data was real. The ODNI email was real. The abstract was accepted. All of it documented, all of it timestamped, all of it created by a person functioning at the highest level of his career.

They broke me down. Then they used the breakdown as the explanation.

And while I was in there, Leidos contacted my mother and directed her to ship the laptop back to the company. I was hospitalized. I could not refuse. She didn't know what she was handing over.

That laptop had everything on it. The alias account created under my name on March 2nd. The Cisco documents I had been directed to sign removing all record of Ryan C. Lingo from the relevant systems. The Webex account pushed remotely to the machine — the one I set up under a name delivered through plausibly deniable directives. The UAP visualization code. The Python scripts. The months of work that Leidos made sure to recover before I could.

By the time I came out the laptop was gone. The Git repository was gone. Both sides of the evidence, client and server, removed while I was in no position to stop any of it. There were two laptops. They took the Leidos machine. The FAA laptop stayed. They knew which one they needed.

I lay in Horsham and didn't know any of this yet.

I was just trying to remain a person.

At some point they decided I could leave.

That's how it works. There is no ceremony, no resolution, no moment where someone sits across from you and acknowledges what you came in carrying. There is paperwork. There are your things in a bag. There is a door that opens from the inside now.

I walked out.

I didn't know yet the full shape of what had been taken while I was in no position to stop it.

I would find out.

Chapter 5: The Noise

My brother picked me up in his truck.

I don't remember much about the drive except that at some point a car backed out of a driveway without looking and we came close enough that I braced. Nobody said anything. We kept driving.

I didn't have my car. That was one of the things the preceding weeks had taken, one entry in a list that was longer than I had fully processed yet. I was in the passenger seat. Someone else driving.

I was depressed in the specific way you are when something has been done to you that no one around you will name. Not grief exactly. More like the aftermath of a verdict you didn't agree with, delivered by people who hadn't heard your side.

I was home. Whatever that meant now.

What I didn't know yet was that while I was gone, my parents had moved me out of my apartment in Washington. Everything I had built there — the proximity to the work, the life I had made in that city — had been packed up and removed while I was in no position to stop it.

I found out after. My parents had been trying to help. I understood that then and I understand it now.

It didn't make it hurt less.

Before I could do anything else I had to get my access back.

My FAA account had been removed while I was incapacitated. My PIV card — the physical hardware token required to access federal systems — was no longer valid. I coordinated with an Aviation Safety Assistant at the Allentown FSDO, and physically traveled to the FAA office with my government laptop to have it restored. The emails documenting that process exist. June 2023. A month and a half after I had walked out of Horsham.

That is what returning to work looked like. Not a welcome back. Not an acknowledgment of what had happened. A trip to a federal office to prove I was still authorized to do the job I had been doing before they took everything.

The phone was still mine. That was one thing they hadn't taken.

I don't remember exactly when I first noticed it — but at some point I was scrolling and something stopped me. A song title. Then another. Then the algorithm serving me an album I hadn't searched for, an artist I hadn't played, a title that sat in my chest like a word spoken directly to me. This was the same period I was filing complaints with federal agencies, reaching congressional offices, and looking for attorneys. The content arrived alongside all of it.

Compliance. Hostage. Break You Hard. Gag Order.

I want to be precise about this because I know how it sounds. A song is a song. An algorithm is an algorithm. I was also a person who had spent months building a tool specifically designed to distinguish between coincidence and pattern, to draw a line between two points and ask whether the geometry held.

The geometry held.

What people don't understand about this kind of thing — the deniable kind, the kind designed to leave no fingerprints — is that it works precisely because it sounds crazy when you describe it. That's not a flaw in the method. That's the method. You can't walk into a room and say the algorithm is being used to threaten me without watching the air go out of the conversation. You can't file a complaint about a song title. There is no form for this. There is no investigator whose job it is to look at a carousel of music recommendations and assess whether they constitute intimidation.

They knew that. They had always known that.

So I didn't tell anyone. I had already learned what happened when I told people things they weren't prepared to believe. My family had heard me say things before the hospitalization that they had filed neatly away as symptoms. The institutional record had done the same. I had been given a diagnosis and a prescription and a discharge date, and the world had moved on with the comfortable certainty that the problem had been located and treated.

The problem had not been treated. It had simply changed channels.

I took a screenshot. Then another. Every morning I picked up the phone not knowing what would be waiting — which title, which image, which piece of content calibrated just precisely enough to land. Apple Music. Instagram. It didn't matter which app I opened. The themes followed me across platforms, across ecosystems, as if the content knew where I was going before I got there. And every morning I documented it.

Not because I thought anyone was watching. Not because I had a plan yet. But because I was a geographer. A data person. And data, I had learned, was the only language that survived contact with institutions.

If no one was going to believe my testimony, I would give them something harder to dismiss.

I saved everything.

The content escalated. That's the honest way to describe it, not a dramatic shift, not a single moment, but a gradual pressure applied with precision over days and weeks until the accumulation became undeniable.

It wasn't just song titles anymore.

There is a term for what I was experiencing. Several, actually. I want to name them here precisely because the naming matters. Because one of the ways this kind of operation sustains itself is by existing in a space that feels too strange to describe, too personal to be taken seriously, too diffuse to be actionable. Giving it a name collapses that space.

The first term is **cognitive warfare**. Recognized by NATO, discussed in congressional testimony, documented in military and intelligence literature. It refers to the use of information environments — social media, algorithmic content delivery, digital platforms — to influence, exhaust, and destabilize a target's perception and decision-making capacity. Not propaganda in the traditional sense. Something more precise. Something that operates below the threshold of what most people would recognize as an attack.

The second is **plausibly deniable intimidation**. The delivery of threats through channels that cannot be traced, attributed, or reported through any existing institutional mechanism. A song title is not a threat. A job listing is not a threat. A news story about a dead whistleblower is not a threat. Each element, examined individually, is nothing. That's the architecture. The deniability isn't incidental. It's the point.

The third is **psychologically tailored targeting**. The use of personal data — your relationships, your fears, your history, your professional identity — to calibrate content specifically to you. Not generic threatening content. Specific content. Boeing, because I had worked in aerospace and national security. My mother, because they knew who I loved and what I stood to lose. The whistleblowers, because they knew exactly what category I had placed myself in and what fate that category carried.

The fourth is **attrition by exhaustion**. The strategic goal underlying all of it. You don't need to silence someone with a single decisive blow if you can make the baseline cost of existing high enough that resistance becomes unsustainable on its own. Every morning the phone was there before I was. Every morning there was something waiting: a video, a listing, a story, a title, that had to be processed, documented, survived, before I could begin the actual work of fighting back.

On Instagram, videos of Boeing whistleblowers appeared in my feed. Repeatedly. Men who had known things, who had tried to say them, who had ended up in hospitals or morgues with explanations that satisfied everyone except the people paying attention. The algorithm served them to me the way you'd serve a warning to someone you wanted to understand their options.

On LinkedIn, promoted job listings appeared. Boeing. Johns Hopkins Applied Physics Laboratory. Institutions with deep roots in defense, aerospace, intelligence contracting. A reminder of the world I had come from and what happened to people who talked about it.

I was applying for federal and federal contracting roles simultaneously. On LinkedIn and Indeed I was being served bat biologist and boat captain as top picks. For months the platforms pushed recommendations that had nothing to do with my background and everything to do with keeping me away from the work I was qualified for. I had a Master's degree. I had been a Geographer for the United States Census Bureau. I had held a SECRET clearance. The algorithm had filed me somewhere else entirely.

Then there was the video. "They're gonna execute the mother." Rendered in block letters over footage of a burning landscape. Delivered through the same feed that showed me home décor and travel content and the ordinary noise of other people's lives. Just sitting there. Waiting.

There was a virtual appointment with my doctor that summer. I was sitting in my parents' basement, on the call, trying to explain what had been happening — the content, the pattern, the daily intimidation. Directly across from me, on the smart TV, two movie advertisements cycled on a loop. Role Play. And a second title with the word Death in it. Rotating. While I talked.

I was telling a doctor I was being targeted. The TV was making the point for them.

I saved it.

I saved all of it, because I had learned by then that the only thing standing between me and complete institutional erasure was the record I was building myself. No one was going to build it for me. The OIGs had closed their doors. The lawyers were still deciding. Congress was listening but slowly, the way institutions listen when they're not sure yet what they're looking at.

And every day, before I could make a call or send an email or sit across from someone who might finally understand what I was describing, the phone would have been there first. Draining something harder to recharge than a battery.

That's what attrition by exhaustion looks like from the inside. They didn't need to stop me outright. They just needed me to arrive at every important conversation already emptied out. Already worn down to the place where fighting felt like too much.

Some days it worked.

Some days I made the call anyway.

I was not only documenting. I was still fighting.

That's the thing that gets lost in any account of this period, the assumption that a person being targeted is only surviving. That the harassment and the resistance are mutually exclusive. They weren't. Every morning I picked up the phone and found what was waiting, and then I put the phone down and kept going.

I was working with congressman Brian Fitzpatrick's office. I was in contact with Senator Bob Casey's office. I was reaching lawyers. I was trying to move the institutional machinery that had already failed me once, and twice, and more times than I had fully counted. A congressman. A U.S. Senator. Attorneys. I was not a person who had given up. I was a person working every channel available to him simultaneously, while being targeted every morning before he could begin.

I believed — I had to believe — that if I could get the right person to look at the right document, something would shift.

The formal channels were not shifting.

So I tried to show them what was happening in the only way I had left. They had been sending me content for months — that's what I need you to understand before I tell you what I did next. This wasn't my language. It was theirs. Kesha's *Gag Order* — the album cover, a woman with a plastic bag over her head — had appeared in my feed. Pushed to me. A top pick. My initials in the corner.

I showed it to a congressional staffer. In person. A staffer I had just briefed on my UAP work and what had been done to me by the FAA, Leidos, and the United States Air Force.

Not as a stunt. Not as a metaphor. As evidence. As a way of saying: this is what is appearing on my phone. This is what they are sending me. A woman suffocating. A gag order. Do you see what I am trying to tell you?

They didn't see it.

What I got back was the particular silence that offices are very good at, the kind that isn't refusal exactly, just the absence of acknowledgment. The kind that leaves you holding the thing you tried to hand someone, alone again with it.

I got in my car after. The first song that came on was Nicki Minaj's Gag City Deluxe. I documented it and sent it to the same office.

The silence came back.

I had wishful thinking. I know that now. But I also know that wishful thinking, in the absence of any other viable option, is not weakness. It's endurance. It's the decision to keep trying even when the evidence suggests you shouldn't.

I kept trying.

At some point I stopped waiting for the wall to move.

I'm not sure I can give you a single moment, a specific morning, a specific message, a specific silence that finally tipped it. It was more like an accumulation that reached its limit. The gaslighting. The content. The exhaustion of waking up every day to a phone that had been there before me, doing its work, and then trying to function like a person with something left to give.

I had filed the complaints. I had contacted Congress. I had documented everything I could document and sent it to everyone I could reach. I had tried to speak the language of institutions and the language of algorithms and the language of pop songs and none of it had moved anything.

Enough.

That's the only word for it. Not a strategic calculation. Not a plan. Just the flat, clear recognition that staying was no longer something I was willing to do. That whatever came next, it would not be more of this.

I left.

And for the first time in longer than I could measure, the decision was entirely mine.

Chapter 6: The External Fight

There is a version of this story in which I am the person who didn't try hard enough. Who gave up too soon. Who failed to find the right door or knock loudly enough or present the evidence in a way that moved someone to act.

I want to address that version directly, and then I want to put it to rest.

What follows is a list. Not a metaphor. Not a characterization. A documented record of every institution, every official, every congressional office, every attorney, and every newsroom I contacted between March 2023 and 2026 in an attempt to find someone — anyone — willing to look at what had been done to me and say: *this matters, and we will do something about it.*

I am going to name them. I am going to give you their titles and their dates. I am going to tell you what they said and what they didn't do.

Not out of bitterness — though I have earned the right to that. Out of precision. Because the pattern is the evidence. Because the accumulation of closed doors is itself a document. Because if you read this list and still believe I didn't try, I don't know what else I can show you.

Part One — Federal Agencies and Officials

DHS Office of Inspector General *March 5, 2023*

I faxed a confidential complaint to the DHS OIG two days after the coercive events of March 2nd. The transmission confirmation shows successful delivery at 9:57 AM. No substantive response was ever received. Two days later I was hospitalized.

The White House — Biden-Harris Administration *March and April 2023*

I contacted the White House twice. Both times I received acknowledgments. The April response confirmed my correspondence had been forwarded to the “appropriate Federal agency for further action.” No agency ever followed up with me directly.

Jodi Votel, EEO Counselor/Specialist — FAA Office of Civil Rights (ACT-9) *May 2023*

I filed EEO complaint #2023-29988. Votel processed it and sent the Rights and Responsibilities documentation. On May 11th I withdrew the complaint. I wrote: “*I am very fearful for my well-being if I move forward with it.*” Votel sent the withdrawal

paperwork. I signed it. I later wrote to her: *“I’d like to add that I signed that memorandum out of fear.”*

FAA Pre-Complaint — Timothy Wallace, Manager, AJR-22 June 22, 2023

I filed a second pre-complaint naming Timothy Wallace, Manager of Operational Security Initiatives, as the responsible management official. I alleged disability discrimination, harassment, and failure to provide reasonable accommodation. I elected ADR. No resolution was ever documented.

Sabina Frederick, Whistleblower Protection Coordinator — DOT OIG

January 11, 2024

Frederick contacted me by phone and then email asking me to clarify my allegations. I responded the same day with a detailed account of the March 2nd events. She responded hours later: *“Based on a review of the information provided in your recent emails, we believe that DOT-OIG lacks oversight regarding your concerns. Additionally, we are not in a position to provide advice and anticipate no further action from our office concerning these matters.”*

Same day. Hours later. No further action.

FBI / Internet Crime Complaint Center (IC3) January 2024

I filed a complaint documenting the March 2nd events as coordinated internet crime — targeted ads on a federal device, alias account creation directives, financial coercion conducted through digital means. No response was ever documented.

Office of Special Counsel (OSC) August 7, 2024

I filed four separate allegations: Abuse of Authority, Censorship Related to Scientific Research, Danger to Public Health, and Violation of Law, Rule or Regulation. The OSC website returned a notification indicating the FAA fell outside its jurisdiction. No active investigation resulted.

Michael Mills, AFDW/IG — Joint Base Andrews July 2024

Mills contacted me after my SAF/IG complaint. He read the case. He asked careful questions and I gave careful answers. He said: *“Right now, everything I’m seeing is either FAA or DoT... If we can’t identify an Air Force issue, then we won’t have a path forward.”* He could not identify an Air Force issue. He closed the case without referral.

Kimberly Mlinaz, Director of NDR — SAF/GCA July 18, 2024

I contacted SAF’s Negotiation and Dispute Resolution office separately. Mlinaz explained that NDR is an internal program — engagement requires a request from the

IG. Mills would need to ask. Mills never asked. The ADR door I had been trying to open since March 2023 was closed procedurally by a person who never made a phone call.

Secretary of Transportation Pete Buttigieg *December 6, 2024*

I sent a formal letter to Secretary Buttigieg at the Department of Transportation. I described the coercive directives, the alias account, the unauthorized medical access, the ongoing intimidation, and the failure of both the DHS and DOT OIGs to take action. I wrote: *“The lack of response from your office has left me feeling unprotected and has seemingly emboldened those responsible.”*

No response was ever received.

Part Two — Congressional Offices

Senator Cory Booker’s Office *February 2024 (approximate)*

I contacted Senator Booker’s office. No substantive response was received.

Senator Tim Burchett’s Office *February 2024 (approximate)*

I contacted Senator Burchett’s office. No substantive response was received.

House Committee on Oversight and Accountability *February 2024 (approximate)*

I contacted the committee directly. No substantive response was received.

Science, Space, and Technology Committee *February 2024 (approximate)*

I contacted the committee directly. No substantive response was received.

Ryan Oister, Senior Advocate — Rep. Brian Fitzpatrick’s Office *March 5, 2024*

I met with Ryan Oister in person at the Langhorne district office. He was kind. He was genuinely interested in UAP disclosure — he mentioned David Grusch, knew the landscape, understood the broader context better than most people I had spoken to. He gave me an hour.

I was terrified.

I sat across from him and tried to explain what had been done to me and I couldn’t get it out in any order that made sense. The problem wasn’t the time. I told him it felt like an ethical assassination attempt. I said it twice. I showed him my challenge coin. I told him I was afraid of going to jail for saying the wrong thing. I told him I couldn’t share details about the technology. I told him they had used my disability against me. I told him

about the music, the medications, the bank, the GitHub repository. I told him there were people at my workplace who had died and that it was made to look like overdoses.

He listened. He took notes. He said it was a safe space. He asked if I had a written description I could send him. He needed more details.

Towards the end of the conversation, he said he hoped they didn't get a tail on him. He laughed when he said it.

I signed the waiver. I said I would send the written description. I walked out knowing I hadn't said what I needed to say, and that I probably never could have — not in that room, not on that day, not to someone who had never been inside what I was trying to describe.

I sent the written description anyway. He followed up. He forwarded the DOT OIG's declination letter. He offered to follow up with the Air Force OIG on June 25th.

No substantive outcome resulted.

HPSCI — House Permanent Select Committee on Intelligence *March 7, 2024*

I sent a signed letter to HPSCI Members at the Capitol Visitor Center, submitted on my behalf through Representative Brian Fitzpatrick's office. I identified myself as a former Leidos/FAA contractor whose UAP work had been shared with ODNI. I reported threats to my life and safety, requested whistleblower protections, and described being prevented from presenting my work at the 2023 ESRI conference. No response was ever documented.

Molly Peters / McKenzie Cliatt — Senator Bob Casey's Office *February – July 2024*

Senator Casey's office engaged more substantively than most. Peters assigned my case to a constituent advocate. Cliatt requested and received a signed Privacy Act Release Form. The office submitted my complaint to USAF contacts with a 30-business-day response window.

The Air Force responded thirty days later. That response is the subject of the next chapter.

Representative Nancy Mace's Office *November 18, 2024*

I contacted Representative Nancy Mace's office and spoke with a staffer by phone. I submitted a signed privacy release form listing the Department of Defense and Air Force as the agencies involved. I also submitted the HPSCI letter through her office. No substantive response was received.

House Oversight Committee Democrats — Signal February 5, 2026

I sent the HPSCI letter and a message to the Oversight Democrats Signal line. I wrote: *“I believe this was never delivered...sharing to ensure my story does not go unanswered. I worked with Senator Casey’s office and Brian Fitzpatrick.”*

That second message received a thumbs up reaction.

Representative Summer Lee’s Office — Task Force on the Declassification of Federal Secrets March 21, 2026

I emailed Representative Lee’s press office directly, identifying her as a member of the Task Force on the Declassification of Federal Secrets. I sent the same congressional brief and the same evidence. I wrote that I respectfully asked her to review the attached brief and consider referring the matter to the Task Force for further examination.

No response was documented.

Brennen Gelinas — Rep. Anna Paulina Luna’s Office / UAP Task Force March 23, 2026

After calling Rep. Luna’s DC office I emailed Brennen Gelinas, staff member on the Task Force on the Declassification of Federal Secrets. I attached the congressional brief, the Benson email chain, and the Bartlett denial letter. I offered to brief the Task Force in any format at any time. Rep. Luna chairs the Task Force, which held hearings on UAP transparency and whistleblower protection in September 2025. No substantive response was documented at time of writing.

Rep. Jasmine Crockett’s Office — Ranking Member, Task Force on the Declassification of Federal Secrets March 23, 2026

On the same day I contacted Brennen Gelinas in Rep. Luna’s office, I emailed Rep. Crockett’s press office directly. She serves as Ranking Member of the same Task Force — the Democratic counterpart to Luna’s Republican chair. I sent the same congressional brief and the same evidence. I wrote: *“I respectfully ask that you review the attached brief and consider referring this matter to the Task Force for further examination.”*

I contacted both sides of the aisle on the same day. The issue of a Pentagon official making a false statement to a United States Senator is not a partisan one. I wanted the record to show I understood that.

No response was documented from either office.

Part Three — Legal Contacts

The attorneys were different from the institutions. The institutions had power and chose not to use it. The attorneys were being asked to take on a case that most civil litigation firms are not built to handle — a case involving national security, federal contractors, military officials, and a plaintiff whose psychiatric history had been deliberately weaponized against him.

I understand why most of them said no.

I am naming them anyway. Because the search itself was part of what was done to me. Every month spent finding another attorney, explaining everything again from the beginning, waiting for a response, and receiving a polite declination was another month the case aged and the statute of limitations shortened and the people responsible faced no consequence.

Bochetto & Lentz, P.C. — Philadelphia, PA August 6, 2023

Contact form submitted. No representation offered.

Phillips & Cohen LLP — Washington, D.C. March 7, 2024

Matthew Smith reviewed and declined. He wrote: *“Our decision is not intended to suggest that a successful action cannot be maintained.”* He noted the urgency of statute of limitations.

Katz Banks Kumin — Washington, D.C. July 12, 2024

First Contact - Destiny Barber declined on behalf of the firm. Katz Banks Kumin is one of the most prominent whistleblower protection law firms in Washington, D.C. — a firm that specializes in exactly the kind of case I was bringing. They declined.

Eric Siegel Law, PLLC — Washington, D.C. July 25, 2024

LeShante Henry contacted me via referral from the National Whistleblower Legal Defense and Education Fund. I provided a fact timeline and key documents. The firm reviewed and did not offer representation.

Skeen Law Offices — Charlottesville, VA November 11–14, 2024

Michael Turiello reached out via Morgan and Morgan referral. We spoke by phone. I provided my case narrative and supporting documents. He wrote: *“Despite my deepest sympathies for what you’ve experienced, we are unable to take your case.”*

Lundy Law — Philadelphia, PA January 30, 2025

L. Leonard Lundy declined. The letter noted declining to represent “*makes no representation as to the veracity or strength of this potential legal matter.*”

Government Accountability Project (GAP) — Washington, D.C. January 29, 2025

First Contact - Joanne Royce reviewed my Case Narrative and Legal Claims memo and declined representation. She wrote: “*Our declining of services to you does not indicate that our staff thinks your claims to be unimportant or without merit.*”

Katz Banks Kumin — Washington, D.C. July 3, 2025

Second Contact - I contacted them again. Destiny Barber declined again. Same firm. Same result. One year later.

Relman Colfax PLLC — Washington, D.C. July 9, 2025

Caroline Sullivan declined on behalf of the firm. She wrote: “*We regret that we cannot represent all of the worthy and deserving individuals who come to us for help.*”

Government Accountability Project (GAP) — Washington, D.C. April 15, 2026

Second Contact - I applied again. They declined again. The intake team wrote: “*our declining of services to you does not indicate that our staff thinks your concerns are unimportant or without merit.*”

Katz Banks Kumin — Washington, D.C. April 1, 2026

Third Contact - I contacted Lisa Banks, Partner, directly — subject line: “*Potential Civil Claims — Federal Contractor Retaliation and Documented False Statement to U.S. Senator.*” Her out-of-office reply came back. No substantive response followed.

Three contacts. Three years. The same firm. The same result.

Part Four — The Press

I also tried the press.

Not as a last resort. As a parallel channel. The same way I was filing complaints while reaching attorneys, I was reaching journalists. The formal record and the public record are different things. I wanted both.

NewsNation March 5, 2024

I contacted NewsNation and described what had happened in so many words. I shared the HPSCI letter and the details of the retaliation. No substantive response was received.

Washington Post — Matea Gold *February 29, 2024*

I emailed Matea Gold directly. I identified myself by name, explained that anonymity was impossible given the UAP connection, and listed the congressional offices I had already contacted. No response was documented.

6ABC Philadelphia *March 6, 2024*

I contacted 6ABC by email and spoke with someone by phone. They gave me a contact number. Nothing came of it.

WJLA Washington *March 6 and March 23, 2024*

I emailed the WJLA news desk twice. The first email bounced with a DNS error. I tried again on March 23rd. No substantive response was received.

BBC *March 2024 (approximate)*

I contacted the BBC around the time of my congressional outreach. I identified myself, shared the HPSCI letter and my Air Force complaint, and noted I was working with senators on the case. No substantive response was received.

CNN *June 6, 2024*

I sent a tip via Proton Mail. I described the March 2023 coercive events, the alias account, the ESRI abstract, the retaliation. I wrote: *“If there is somebody at CNN who does care, maybe forward this to that person.”* I noted that the Washington Post and the New York Times had not responded to prior outreach. No response was documented from CNN.

NBC News *July 2, 2025*

I submitted a formal tip to NBC News investigative teams identifying myself as a former Leidos contractor whose UAP visualization work had been shared with ODNI. I described the coercive directives, the alias accounts, the psychiatric targeting, and the retaliation. NBC News Customer Care confirmed receipt and said they would forward it for review. No journalist followed up.

The Intercept, ProPublica, The Washington Post, The Guardian, CBC *July 2025*

I BCC'd five investigative outlets on my urgent appeal to the UN Office of the High Commissioner for Human Rights. The same story. The same documents. Five newsrooms. No response was documented from any of them.

The press, like the institutions, like the attorneys, received the information and returned the silence.

That is the list.

Federal agencies. Congressional offices. Attorneys. Newsrooms. Every door I knocked on between March 2023 and 2026. Every name, every title, every date, every polite declination and bureaucratic non-answer and carefully worded acknowledgment that amounted to nothing.

Not without merit. Worthy and deserving. Deepest sympathies. We will forward your message for review.

The words were always kind. The doors were always closed.

I kept knocking anyway. I am still knocking.

This book is a knock.

Chapter 7: Benson and Bartlett

By January 2024 my life had gotten very small.

That's not a complaint — it's a description. After everything that had happened, small was what I could manage. I was working for my parents. Learning new systems. Helping design a website. I got to work around nine or nine-thirty. The work was quiet and ordinary and completely disconnected from anything that had a security clearance attached to it.

I had resigned from Leidos the previous August. Cited ethics. Meant it. In the months between that resignation and January I had done an intensive outpatient program, gotten through it, and landed here — in my parents' business, in a small office, trying to remember what a normal day felt like.

I was getting AWS certified in my spare time. That's the detail that still sits with me when I think about that period. Even then — even after everything — I was preparing. For what, I couldn't have said precisely. For something that used the skills I had. For a place where the work I knew how to do still mattered. I couldn't stop reaching toward the version of my career that had existed before March 2, 2023. I didn't know how to be someone who didn't do that work.

I had also been applying for Air Force positions. Regularly. They sent job listings and I applied to them. I kept applying. I want to be honest about that because it matters for everything that follows — because it is the most psychologically true thing I can tell you about where I was during that period. I knew what had happened to me. I knew who had been involved. And I kept sending in applications anyway.

There is a term for what that looks like from the outside. I am aware of it. What I can tell you from the inside is that the work was still real to me. The mission was still real. The skills I had built — the GIS tools, the UAP visualization, the spatial analysis, the Python scripts written line by line in a Navy Yard apartment — those didn't stop being mine just because the people who had access to them had used that access to destroy me. I couldn't separate the work from the apparatus. I didn't know how.

On January 31, 2024, Dr. Jennifer Benson emailed me.

Her title was Chief Space Scientist. Her unit was the 2nd Weather Squadron, 557th Weather Wing. Her email address ended in @us.af.mil. I had applied for the position — IT Specialist, Software Developer, GS-2210-11 — at Offutt Air Force Base in Nebraska.

The Air Force.

I want you to understand what it meant for that email to arrive when it did. Not strategically — I'll get to that. But personally. I had spent the better part of a year trying to recover from what had been done to me by people operating within and around the national security apparatus. I had been hospitalized. I had been through intensive outpatient programs. I had resigned from the job I had been directed to return to. I was sitting in a small office helping my parents build a website.

And the Air Force was writing back.

Part of me — and I am being completely honest here — wanted to say yes.

The interview went well. I told them what I was good at. I described my aspirations — the tools I wanted to build, the problems I wanted to solve, the kind of work I had always believed I was meant to do. I expressed genuine thanks for their time. I meant it.

I was also scared in a way I couldn't fully name. Whether they showed their faces on the call I can't remember now — that part has blurred the way certain details blur when the emotional register of a memory is too high for the specifics to hold. What I remember is the feeling. Sitting in an interview with people connected to the institution that had harmed me, trying to present myself as a candidate, trying to believe this was a real opportunity and not something else entirely.

Dr. Benson's follow-up arrived on February 22nd.

We were impressed with your background and think that your experience and skills will be a valuable asset to 2d Weather Squadron.

I read that sentence more than once. I want to be honest about what it did to me. After everything — the hospitalization, the outpatient programs, the months of sleeping until the afternoon, the reduced work, the small office, the website — someone at the Air Force had looked at my background and said: valuable asset. Someone had looked at what I had built and recognized it.

There was also a second position. Dr. Benson mentioned an Operations Research Analyst role — GS-1515-12 — focused on tailored product development for the DoD and Intelligence Community. Advanced computational capabilities. Terrestrial and space environmental conditions. My existing SECRET clearance noted. A TS/SCI would be required.

They were offering me more than I had applied for.

I started thinking about Omaha. I looked at flights. I bought a ticket — not for the interview, just to go see the city. To imagine myself there. To make it real in the way that

booking a flight makes things real, when the idea of a place stops being abstract and becomes a departure gate and a seat assignment.

I am aware of how this reads. I am telling you anyway because it is what happened.

I never went.

I never cancelled the ticket either.

The trip was being planned in a way that felt less like me. The same ads. The same suggestions appearing in the same way they had been appearing for months, pointing me somewhere, shaping the idea of where I was going next. I had learned to notice that. I noticed it about Omaha. And I couldn't tell anymore whether I was choosing to go or being directed there — whether the excitement was mine or whether it had been placed in front of me the way everything else had been placed in front of me, calibrated and deniable and waiting for me to follow.

I didn't follow.

The ticket sat unused. Somewhere between wanting to go and understanding what going might mean, I stayed where I was.

On the morning of March 1st, I emailed Dr. Benson and Captain Pearson.

Due to ongoing intimidation and threats against my life, I am no longer interested in pursuing these opportunities.

That's what I wrote. Not a long explanation. Not a detailed account of what had been happening — I had learned by then that detailed accounts of what had been happening tended to end conversations rather than open them. Just the facts of it. Ongoing intimidation. Threats against my life. No longer interested.

It was the accumulation. That's the honest answer to why that morning and not another. There was no single thing — no specific piece of content, no particular moment that broke through where others hadn't. It was the weight of all of it together. The ads. The content. The same deniable architecture that had been running since before the hospitalization, still running, still calibrated, still pointing and suggesting and threatening in the way that left no fingerprints and no recourse. I had been trying to interview for a position at Offutt Air Force Base while the same apparatus that surrounded everything was still operating around me. I couldn't keep doing both.

Captain Benjamin Pearson responded in sixteen minutes.

I want to be precise about that because the timing matters. Sixteen minutes. Not the next day. Not after consultation with HR or legal or whoever handles these things. Sixteen minutes after I wrote that I was withdrawing due to threats against my life, an Air Force captain wrote back.

I completely understand your health and safety are paramount. If you would like to have a private phone conversation concerning this you can reach out to me. I can also provide you with contact information for the Air Force Office of Special Investigations — our military version of the FBI — who may be able to assist you if these threats are due to you applying for the position.

Read that again.

He was offering me AFOSI. The Air Force's own investigative service. Acknowledging explicitly that the threats I was experiencing might be connected to the fact that I had applied for an Air Force position. That is not a boilerplate response. That is a captain at Offutt Air Force Base taking seriously, within sixteen minutes, the possibility that something connected to his institution was threatening a job applicant's life.

I thanked him. I said I hoped things would get figured out soon.

On March 15th I followed up.

I told them I was still interested if the intimidation cleared up.

I know how that reads. I have already told you I know how that reads. What I can tell you is that the work was still real and the mission was still real and I was a person who had been trying to find a safe place inside this apparatus for the better part of a year and I wasn't ready to stop trying. Not yet.

The intimidation did not clear up.

I filed the SAF/IG complaint on June 1, 2024.

It was comprehensive. Named subjects: Leidos, the FAA, the US Air Force, the US Space Force. Cited violations of the Whistleblower Protection Act, the ADA, the Privacy Act, OSHA. Documented the incident period from March 2, 2023 through June 4, 2024. Fifteen months of documented events organized into a formal complaint submitted to the Secretary of the Air Force Inspector General Hotline.

I requested alternative dispute resolution.

That's what I want you to understand about where I was at that point — I wasn't asking for punishment. I wasn't asking for a public reckoning. I was asking for a conversation.

A mediated process in which someone acknowledged what had happened and we figured out what came next. ADR. The most modest accountability mechanism available. You owe me that. You put me through this and you owe me at least that.

Michael Mills from AFDW/IG contacted me on July 2nd.

He said he had read through my case and needed to verify his office was the right one. Asked whether the issue was more with the contract or with the 2nd Weather Squadron. I told him both. We went back and forth.

What followed was a particular kind of frustration I don't have a precise word for. Mills wasn't hostile. He was procedural. He asked careful questions and I gave careful answers — responses I had thought through, organized, documented. Each time I provided a precise account of the Air Force connection he came back with a version of the same question. *I'm trying to see the Air Force nexus*. As if the eleven emails from @us.af.mil addresses didn't exist. As if Captain Pearson's sixteen-minute response offering AFOSI contact hadn't happened. He read what I wrote. He responded to it. And then he returned with the same wall wearing a different question.

On July 18th SAF's Negotiation and Dispute Resolution office responded to a separate inquiry. Kimberly Mlinaz explained that NDR is an internal program — engagement requires a request from the IG. Mills would need to ask. Mills never asked.

The door had been opened just far enough to show me it existed.

Then it closed.

I was angry. Not the hot anger of surprise — I had stopped being surprised. This was the cold anger of someone who understood exactly what was happening and had no remaining mechanism to stop it. They were performing process. Going through the motions of investigation while the conclusion had already been reached. I knew what they were doing. They knew I knew. The wall responded politely and remained a wall.

I stopped pushing on that door.

I went to Congress instead.

Senator Casey's office had done everything correctly.

In late July 2024 I signed a Privacy Act Release Form — handwritten, dated, specific. I named the agencies involved. I described the problem in my own words: retaliation, intimidation, privacy violations, and psychological manipulation related to my work on a sensitive UAP monitoring visualization project. I requested that his office check the

status of my SAF/IG complaint and advocate for alternative dispute resolution. I wrote: *I give written permission to contact agencies involved at your discretion.*

His constituent advocate, McKenzie Cliatt, confirmed that a submission had been delivered to USAF contacts. A 30-business-day response window was given.

They waited. They followed the process. They did everything a senator's office is supposed to do when a constituent comes to them with a documented complaint against a federal agency.

On August 19, 2024, Matthew R. Bartlett wrote back.

Bartlett's title was GS-15 — the highest civilian grade in the federal government below the Senior Executive Service. His position was Deputy Director of Complaints Resolution at SAF/IGQ, the Secretary of the Air Force Inspector General for Complaints. He wrote from 1140 Air Force Pentagon, Washington, D.C. He wrote on official Department of the Air Force letterhead. He digitally signed the letter.

Not a regional office. Not a contractor. The Pentagon.

He wrote: *SAF/IGQ reviewed your correspondence and the IG database. SAF/IGQ found no connection between Mr. Lingo and the US Air Force regarding employment.*

I want you to hold that sentence for a moment.

No connection between Mr. Lingo and the US Air Force regarding employment.

On January 31, 2024, Dr. Jennifer Benson — GS-14, Chief Space Scientist, 2nd Weather Squadron, 557th Weather Wing — emailed me from a @us.af.mil address about a position at Offutt Air Force Base.

On February 13, 2024, I interviewed by phone with the 2nd Weather Squadron.

On February 22, 2024, Dr. Benson wrote: *We were impressed with your background and think that your experience and skills will be a valuable asset to 2d Weather Squadron.* She offered me consideration for a second position — GS-1515-12, Operations Research Analyst — and noted my existing SECRET clearance.

On March 1, 2024, Captain Benjamin Pearson responded to my withdrawal email in sixteen minutes, offering contact with the Air Force Office of Special Investigations.

On March 15, 2024, I followed up expressing continued interest.

Eleven messages. Official Air Force email addresses. An interview. A job offer. A second position. A captain offering AFOSI contact. All of it documented. All of it sitting in my inbox.

Six months later a GS-15 at the Pentagon told a United States Senator there was no connection.

Both of those things cannot be true.

I am not a lawyer. I will not tell you what 18 U.S.C. § 1001 says about false statements made to federal officials or those acting on their behalf. I will tell you that the documents exist. I will tell you that they contradict each other directly and completely. I will tell you that one of them was written by a senior Air Force official at the Pentagon on official letterhead in response to a formal congressional inquiry — an inquiry submitted with my signed permission, through proper channels, with a 30-business-day response window.

They used every day of that window.

And then they said there was no connection.

I have both documents. I have had them since the day Bartlett's letter arrived. I have shown them to congressional offices, to attorneys, to anyone willing to look. The contradiction is not subtle. It does not require interpretation. It sits on the page the way facts sit on a page when they have nowhere left to hide.

This is why I am still here. Still filing. Still sending briefs to congressional offices. Still putting these pages together and naming the names.

The record shows everything.

They just haven't looked at it yet.

Chapter 8: The Cost

I want to try to describe what was lost. Not the job — that comes later. Not the clearance or the career trajectory or the financial stability, though all of those are real and documented and I will get to them. I want to start with something harder to quantify.

I lost the person I was before any of this happened.

That sounds abstract until you understand what that person looked like. He was twenty-nine years old, living alone in Navy Yard, twenty minutes from the White House, in an apartment he had chosen specifically because of where it put him in relation to everything he was building toward. He had a Master's degree and a SECRET clearance and an accepted presentation slot at the largest GIS conference in the world. He had colleagues who relied on him and a supervisor who praised his work and screenshots that had reached the Office of the Director of National Intelligence. He was embedded and trusted and moving toward something significant.

He was someone people knew.

After March 2023 he was someone people had a story about.

The psychiatric hospitalization didn't just happen to me. It happened to my reputation, my relationships, and my family's understanding of who I was. A clinical story had been constructed about me and handed to the people I loved with institutional authority. Not because the people around me were cruel. Because they were scared, and that story was the only explanation they had been given, and they operated inside it in good faith.

My family loves me. I want to say that clearly. What happened to them is the same thing that happened to my mother when she shipped the laptop. They were given a narrative by people with authority and they operated inside it in good faith. They were taken advantage of by the same system that took advantage of me. Even if they don't fully realize it yet.

But the cost of that is real. The waiting for me to become unstable again. The looks. The weight of being someone whose judgment is perpetually in question in the place where you should be safest. That cost is real and I am still paying it.

And then there were my DC friends.

When I left Washington, most of them didn't reach out. Not a text. Not an email. Not a "hey, I haven't seen you around, are you okay." I didn't vanish dramatically. I just stopped being there. And for most of them the silence was complete.

Like it was normal for someone to vanish.

I want to be fair. A handful of people stayed. I know who they are and I haven't forgotten it. But they were the exception. The city I had built a life in largely absorbed my disappearance without a word. The friends who had called themselves my friends when I was embedded and trusted and moving toward something — most of them, when I needed someone to notice I was gone, didn't.

That is grief. The quiet kind. For people who are still alive.

That is where this chapter begins. Not with the numbers — the seventeen months of unemployment, the debt, the reduced clearance level, the career that should have existed but didn't. Those are real and they are coming.

But first: the person who was there before, and the specific shape of his absence.

I remember lying in bed at 1pm when my brother called.

I don't remember what he said. I remember the phone in my hand and the ceiling above me and the particular quality of that hour. Not morning anymore, not afternoon yet, just a blank space in the middle of the day that I had no reason to fill. The medication made everything slow and heavy. The days had no shape. I would surface around noon and lie there for another hour before anything required me to move.

I want to try to describe what that felt like because I don't think there is a clinical word for it. It wasn't depression exactly, though depression was part of it. It was closer to what happens when everything that gave your life structure and meaning and forward momentum is removed simultaneously. The work. The city. The mission. The identity. The colleagues. The apartment. The friends. All of it gone within a matter of weeks, and what remained was a person lying in a bed at 1pm with a phone in his hand and nowhere to be.

There was a black hole where my sense of self had been. That's the most honest description I have. Not a metaphor, a physical sensation. Something in my chest and stomach that had no bottom. They had taken everything. My career. My reputation. My home. My community. My body's relationship with sleep and time and ordinary functioning. And what was left after all of that had been removed was not nothing. It was worse than nothing. It was the shape of what had been there, still present, still felt, just emptied out completely.

I was working for my parents during that period. Getting to the office around nine or nine-thirty when I could manage it. Learning new systems. Helping build a website. My parents gave me a place to land when there was nowhere else. I am grateful for that. But I had spent my entire adult life trying not to need that particular landing place, and

finding myself there, after everything, after the clearance and the conference abstract and the ODNI screenshots, was its own specific grief.

The intensive outpatient program helped. I want to say that. It gave the days a structure they didn't otherwise have. Hours of therapy a week. Medication management. Slowly, something that resembled a baseline began to return.

But slowly is the right word. The blank days were many before they were few.

I wrote in my journal during that period. I wrote affirmations because I needed to remind myself of things that felt in danger of being permanently lost. I am resilient. I am strong. I am courageous. I am brave. I wrote them down because saying them out loud felt like too much to ask of myself. Writing them felt like the minimum. The smallest possible act of not giving up.

Some mornings it was enough.

The NGA sent me a HireVue invitation in June 2024.

I want to be precise about what that means. The National Geospatial-Intelligence Agency is a combat support agency inside the Intelligence Community. Getting selected for an interview there, more than a year after everything had been taken from me, while I was still rebuilding a baseline and still writing affirmations in a journal just to get through the morning, meant that my qualifications were still competitive at the level where I had always believed I belonged. They looked at my file and decided I was worth interviewing. That mattered to me in a way that's hard to explain without sounding desperate, which I was.

The interview opened June 21. I completed it the same day, the day I left for a scheduled trip to Canada. I want to note that timing because it did not feel accidental. The IC has access to calendars. They have access to a great deal. Scheduling an asynchronous interview to open the morning of a departure felt like a test of whether I would rush, or panic, or miss it entirely. I didn't miss it. I sat down and completed it before I got in the car.

What I couldn't do was relocate.

The position required it. NGA Charlottesville, Bolling, Suitland. All of them required me to move. And the seventeen months of unemployment they had put me through had made relocation impossible. You don't save money when you have no income. You don't build flexibility when you're incurring debt just to survive. The IC had taken me from six figures to nothing and then dangled a role that required the financial stability they had

destroyed. There was no anger sharp enough for that. Just helplessness. The quiet kind, where you understand exactly what's happening and can't do anything about it.

The NSA tested me in April 2024. I have the email. The CIA got further, far enough that I was presented with an agreement to sign. I won't describe it in technical detail, but its effect would have been to limit what I could say publicly about the exact topics I had been trying to say things about. I read it and understood immediately what it was. That signature was what stood between me and being hired. I didn't sign.

I watched that door close.

I want to be honest about what that period felt like from the inside. I wasn't being considered by multiple agencies because the IC was generous. I was being moved between them, NGA, NSA, CIA, like something being sorted. Assessed for where I could be placed in a way that kept me contained and employed and quiet. The message underneath all of it, never stated, was: *we are still in control of you and what happens to you. We don't care what we cost you. We are still in control.*

I wanted my old life back. I wanted the clearance and the mission and the work that felt like it meant something. The intelligence role felt like home because it was home. It was where I had been before they took it. Every application was an attempt to return to the person I had been in Navy Yard, twenty minutes from the White House, building something that mattered.

They were losses. Every one of them. The NGA because of debt they created. The NSA because of a process that went nowhere. The CIA because of a signature I wouldn't give them.

I don't regret the signature.

But I grieved the door.

There was one other thing I held onto during that period. In March 2024, a LinkedIn notification arrived in the alias inbox, the account I had been directed to create, the one that still existed, the one I hadn't deleted because I couldn't bring myself to. The profile was under the name Riley Gaines. Seventy-five views. I didn't create that profile. But I kept the notification. Because some part of me was still afraid of them and still wanted back in at the same time. That's the thing about an institution that destroys you. It doesn't stop feeling like home. The machine had taken everything from me and I still wanted to be inside it, still believed the work that had started under that name wasn't finished, still thought maybe I was the one who was supposed to finish it. That's what they don't account for when they dismantle a person. The part that keeps waiting for things to go back to normal. The part that sees an email from a name that isn't yours and thinks: *maybe it's not over yet.*

Leidos ended in August 2023. The same month I started an intensive outpatient program: structured daily therapy for people whose depression has made ordinary functioning impossible. That's what they left me with.

Four months without income followed. Then I went to work for my parents.

I want to say that plainly because the plainness of it is the point. I had a Master's degree. A SECRET clearance. An accepted presentation slot at the largest GIS conference in the world. Screenshots of my work that had reached the Office of the Director of National Intelligence.

I went to work for my parents.

They were good to me. They found things that weren't nothing — social media, a website rebuild, tasks that required a brain. They gave me a place to land. I am grateful for that and I mean it. But I had spent my entire adult life building distance from needing that particular landing place. Getting out of Pennsylvania on my own terms was the thing. The clearance, the apartment in Navy Yard, the federal contract — all of it was proof that I had done it. Finding myself back inside my family's orbit, working for their company, was a specific kind of grief that sat underneath everything else and didn't announce itself.

I applied for jobs the entire time. Deloitte. Booz Allen Hamilton, where Edward Snowden had worked before anyone knew his name. Companies in DC and Virginia that I was qualified for on paper and never heard back from. Not rejections exactly — silence, and then a form letter, and then silence again. The same boilerplate arriving over and over until the pattern became its own answer. I don't have proof of what that pattern meant. I know what it felt like. It felt like a wall that had no door and no sign and no one standing in front of it to tell you that you weren't getting through.

There were days at my parents' office that I remember clearly for reasons that had nothing to do with the work I was supposed to be doing there. I filed a complaint with the FBI from that desk. I wrote letters to Congress from that desk. I did outreach from that desk that I couldn't explain to anyone in the building because my family had their own ideas about what I was dealing with. I would share what I had found, what I had documented, and it would be absorbed into the silence the way everything else was. They loved me. They didn't believe me. Those two things coexisted in the same room every day.

The intimidation didn't stay outside. There were days it felt like it had followed me onto my parents' computer systems. I didn't say anything about it. There was no version of that conversation that ended well.

What kept me going in that office, honestly, was the creative work. Adobe, photo editing, the website rebuild. I found something real in it. The creativity was a relief — the one part of each day that asked something of me I could actually give without it costing me something I didn't have.

I had a second intensive outpatient program in the spring of 2024. I completed it June 6th.

In January 2025, XTS hired me.

Seventeen months after Leidos. My clearance level was public trust. Not SECRET. Public trust.

The work was not what I had been building toward. I spent my days reading through inherited scripts, line by line, methodical work that required attention but not vision. I had built something that reached ODNI. That distance was not abstract. I felt it every day.

There was a senior leader at XTS who appeared on our monthly video calls. I don't remember his name. What I remember is the CIA emblem on the wall behind him. I would sit in those calls and look at it and think: they moved me here. They know where I belong and they put me here anyway.

I don't know if it was intentional.

I know what it felt like.

At some point staying stopped being a question.

I want to be precise about what I mean by that, because it's easy to read it as despair and it wasn't exactly despair. It was closer to a calculation that had finally completed. I had filed complaints with the DHS OIG, the DOT OIG, the FAA, the SAF/IG, the OSC, the FBI. I had written to the White House, to Senator Casey, to Representative Fitzpatrick, to the House Permanent Select Committee on Intelligence. I had contacted GAP, who told me my claims were not without merit and then declined representation. I had done everything the system told me to do, through every channel the system provided, and the system had looked back at me with complete indifference.

The intimidation didn't stop while I was doing any of this. It adapted. It moved through the ecosystem the way it always had, the same one that had been running since March 2, 2023. The feeds, the platforms, the devices, the digital environment that surrounds a person so completely they stop noticing it until something in it is pointed directly at them. Suicide-adjacent content in the feed. An album called *Gag Order* promoted as a top pick. An Instagram post with the words *execute the mother*. A video captioned *when*

you hang yourself instead of Christmas stockings. POV content framed around being kidnapped, appearing repeatedly through 2025. On September 9th, in the minutes I was writing my resignation from XTS, I opened Instagram and was shown a video referencing the Director of National Intelligence. I documented it the next day. The timing felt like punctuation. Not every piece of this was provably targeted. But the pattern had been consistent since March 2023, and by 2025 I had stopped trying to convince anyone it was coincidence.

I put together a binder. A hundred and twenty pages. Everything I had documented about the digital environment — Instagram, Apple, the full ecosystem — organized and printed and placed into a physical record that I could carry across a border. I was not going in empty-handed. That mattered to me. Whatever happened on the other side, I was going to arrive with evidence in my hands.

My boyfriend knew what I was doing. We both knew there was a chance it could work, that I could walk through that border and not come back, that the next chapter of this story could be told from somewhere else. We didn't talk about that possibility too directly. But the weight of it was real. The specific kind of scared that comes not from believing something will fail but from allowing yourself to believe it might succeed.

We drove separately. I needed my car.

On September 15, 2025, I presented myself at the Canadian border and requested asylum.

I cried for most of it. I'm not sure for how long exactly. Twenty minutes, maybe more. I told them what had happened in so many words — that whistleblowers were being tormented, that I had documentation, that I had tried every channel available to me inside the United States and every one of them had failed. They searched my car. They found the binder. A hundred and twenty pages of everything I had documented about the digital environment, the platforms, the ecosystem, organized and printed and carried across that border in my hands because I was not going in empty-handed.

They told me asylum was impossible. That if I stayed I would be held in an immigration detention center for months while my case was processed. The officer did not allow me to sign the withdrawal form himself. He sent me back.

I drove home alone. Back across the border with the binder in the backseat and the form somewhere in the car and the particular silence of a person who has just run out of road.

That is what the end of a threshold looks like from the inside. Not a dramatic break. Not a moment of clarity or resolve. Just a form in your hand, and a border behind you, and the slow understanding that you are going to have to find another way.

I'm still looking.

Epilogue: Still Fighting

We stopped at Niagara Falls before I crossed. I don't know whose idea it was. We had driven up separately, two cars from Pennsylvania, his and mine, because I needed my car on the other side if it worked. We stood at the falls for a while. The water doesn't care about any of it. Not the binder in the backseat, not the border twenty minutes north, not what was about to happen. It just goes. We didn't say much. We both knew there was a chance I wouldn't be coming back, that the next chapter of this story would be told from somewhere else. We didn't say that out loud. But we both knew it, and we stood there in it until there was nothing left to do but go.

He turned south. I turned north.

I crossed alone.

The drive back took a long time, or felt that way. Just highway and the particular silence of a person replaying everything that had happened in a room they couldn't go back to. The male officer's voice. The White House letter he held up and called boilerplate. The female officer who could see it, who looked at my outline and knew I was telling the truth, and still couldn't do anything about it. I had told them I would rather sit in a detention center for months than return to the United States. I had meant it. They walked me out to my car anyway.

I thought about what I was driving back to. No job. I had resigned from XTS six days before the crossing because I was not going to ask a new country for protection while still employed by one connected to the apparatus I was fleeing. My parents had made clear they needed me to find work before I could come back home. So there was no apartment, no income, no institutional footing of any kind. Just the binder in the backseat and the road that kept going south.

When I got to his apartment I told him everything. The room. The two officers. Being walked to my car. Driving down the wrong lane when I pulled away, the guards yelling, correcting course. The CBP officer on the American side who said they had no problem with me coming back, sympathetic in the way people are when there is nothing they are required to do.

He was there. That's what I remember most clearly about that night. Not what was said. Just that he was there, and that after everything, the border, the drive, the road that felt like it had no end, that was the one thing still standing.

I didn't have a plan. What I had was the understanding, somewhere below the exhaustion, that I was not done. Whatever the crossing had taken, it had not taken the

fight. I had no job, no apartment, no channel left untried. The fight had nowhere else to go but forward.

By the time I found stable ground again I had a job and a life that had some shape to it. Not what I had before March 2023, not Navy Yard and a SECRET clearance and a presentation slot at the largest GIS conference in the world. But a real apartment, split with my boyfriend, in a place I actually liked. That mattered more than I expected it to.

I started over with the timeline.

I had no formal training in any of what the previous three years had required of me. No legal background, no experience writing to senators or filing IG complaints or drafting correspondence that had to hold up against institutional scrutiny. I had learned all of it by doing it, under pressure, in real time. What I had was the geographer's instinct, the data person's reflex. You lay everything out in sequence. You look for where things don't line up. If the pattern is there, the record will show it.

So I rebuilt the timeline from scratch. Every document, every date, every closed door laid out in order. I shared the details the way I had always worked, methodically, one entry at a time, sharing the source documents as I went. The job interview with Dr. Benson. The eleven messages. The offer of consideration for two positions. Captain Pearson's response about the Air Force Office of Special Investigations.

Then the Bartlett letter.

One sentence. August 2024. A GS-15 Deputy Director telling Senator Casey that SAF/IGQ had reviewed the database and found no connection between Ryan Lingo and the United States Air Force.

I had just entered the eleven emails from @us.af.mil addresses.

Both things were sitting in the same document. The recruitment and the denial. The Air Force that had contacted me, interviewed me, praised my background, offered me positions, and the Air Force official who told a sitting United States Senator it had never happened.

That was the crack. The first one in three years that went all the way through.

I was not emotional about it. What I felt was closer to the satisfaction of a data set that has finally resolved. I had known the contradiction existed. Now I had it organized, documented, and visible on a page in a way that anyone could read in thirty seconds. I sent it to lawyers. I sent it to Congress. I built the brief around it.

The geographer had found the anomaly. Now someone with authority needed to look at it.

I called Representative Luna's office in March 2026.

I expected a voicemail. After everything, after every call and every form and every letter that had disappeared into the silence, I had learned to expect nothing. I kept it short. I had learned that the window, when it opened at all, was narrow, and I had practiced being succinct because of that.

Brennen Gelinas answered.

I got my point across in the time I had. He gave me his email. He said he would get it to the proper task force.

It was later in the day when I hung up, after work, the sun going down. I had one thing to do and I needed to do it before anything could interrupt it. Three years of watching documents disappear, accounts get deleted, evidence get removed while I was in no position to stop it. I was not going to let this brief sit in a draft folder overnight. I sent it that evening. The 2nd Weather Squadron emails. The SAF/IGQ denial. The contradiction, documented, organized, two columns, readable in thirty seconds.

Then I called Representative Jasmine Crockett's office. That staffer directed me to the House Oversight Committee's whistleblower tipline. I sent it there too.

Rep. Luna chairs the House Oversight Committee's Task Force on the Declassification of Federal Secrets. She had held hearings on UAP transparency. Her staff had taken my call. Brennen Gelinas had given me his email and said the words I'll get this to the right people.

For a moment, a real one, it felt like something might move.

I held onto that for a while.

Nothing has happened.

No response to the email. No response to the follow-up. The brief went in and the silence came back, the same silence that has answered every channel I have tried since March 2023. The OIGs. The White House. The FAA. The SAF/IG. The OSC. The FBI. The DOT. Senator Casey. Representative Fitzpatrick. Representative Mace. The Government Accountability Project. The UN. Canada.

The attorneys are their own category. Bochetto and Lentz. Phillips and Cohen. Katz Banks Kumin, twice. Eric Siegel Law. Skeen Law Offices. Lundy Law. Relman Colfax. Several of them said the same thing in different words: our decision is not a reflection on the merits of your case. Phillips and Cohen wrote that a successful action could not be ruled out. GAP wrote that my claims were not unimportant and not without merit. Then they all referred me to NELA and wished me luck.

I am still looking.

That is where things stand. Not resolved, not abandoned. The record exists. The documents exist. I have a Master's degree and a SECRET clearance and a geographer's understanding of what it means when the data doesn't lie. I have the Benson emails and the Bartlett denial and the contradiction sitting between them that no one has been able to explain away, because it cannot be explained away. I have journal entries written the night before they hospitalized me. I have a book that cannot be retrieved, cannot be shipped back, cannot be removed while I am incapacitated.

They took a great deal from me. The record was not among it.

If you are reading this, you are part of the record now.

That is not a small thing. Every person who finishes this book and understands what happened is one more person the silence cannot reach. They built the silence carefully. They counted on it. They counted on closed doors and institutional indifference and the particular exhaustion that sets in when a person has tried every channel available to them and been turned away at every one. They counted on me running out of road.

I have not run out of road.

To whoever is reading this with the standing to act, a journalist, a congressional staffer, an attorney, someone who knows someone who knows someone: the documents are real. The contradiction is documented. A GS-14 Air Force scientist recruited me in eleven emails from official Air Force addresses. A GS-15 Pentagon official told a United States Senator in writing that no such connection existed. Both of those things cannot be true. One of them is a documented false statement to a sitting member of Congress. That is where the investigation begins, if someone is willing to begin it.

To the whistleblowers reading this: I see you. Whatever they are doing to you, whatever version of this you are living through right now, I believe you. The pattern is real. The targeting is real. The institutional indifference is real and it is not an accident. You are not imagining it and you are not alone. Build the record. Name the names. Keep going.

To Leidos, to the FAA, to the United States Air Force, to everyone who was in that room on March 2nd and everyone who was complicit in what followed: the record exists. It has been preserved, documented, printed, and placed into the hands of the public. There is a community of people now who know what happened. Justice has a way of arriving on its own timeline, and the people who seek it on my behalf will not stop. Neither will I.

I still have hope. That is the most defiant thing I can tell you. After three years of closed doors and silence and institutions that looked at the evidence and found reasons not to act, I am still here, still fighting, still certain that the truth documented in these pages will find the people with the power to do something about it.

The record exists.

Find it. Share it. Do something with it.

About the Author

Ryan Charles Lingo, M.A. is a geographer, GIS developer, and former federal employee and contractor who worked within the Federal Aviation Administration's Operations Security Strategic Initiatives Team under Leidos Inc. Prior to his work at the FAA, he served as a Geographer with the United States Census Bureau in Washington, D.C. He holds a Master of Arts in Geography and Environmental Planning from Towson University and has conducted research in partnership with NASA's DEVELOP National Program and the NOAA World Data Center for Paleoclimatology. He held a SECRET-level security clearance.

While working as a GIS Software Developer embedded within the FAA, Lingo developed a UAP monitoring and visualization prototype in response to statistically significant increases in UAP reports to the Air Traffic Control System Command Center. His research abstract, *Comparing Reports of Unidentified Aerial Phenomena to Starlink Satellite Orbits*, was accepted for presentation at the 2023 ESRI User Conference. His work reached the Office of the Director of National Intelligence.

Following retaliation for his disclosures, Lingo filed formal complaints with the DHS Office of Inspector General, the FAA Office of Civil Rights, the Office of Special Counsel, and the Secretary of the Air Force Inspector General. He submitted testimony to the House Permanent Select Committee on Intelligence and worked with the offices of Representative Brian Fitzpatrick and Senator Bob Casey. He submitted an urgent appeal to the UN Office of the High Commissioner for Human Rights. A congressional brief presenting a direct contradiction between Pentagon records and a formal response to a United States Senator remains under active review.

Plausibly Deniable is his first book.